Friday, January 26, 2024
Magh 12, 2080 | Nepal Sambat 1144 | Pohelaga Paru

NATION'S 1ST ENGLISH BROADSHEET

risingnepaldaily.com
Vol. LIX, No. 41 | Pages 8+4 | Rs. 5 | National Edition

THE RISING NEPAL

ALL BE HAPPY, ALL BE WELL



PHOTO: PM'S SECRETARIAT

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' with office bearers of the Former Judges' Society at PM's official residence in Baluwatar, Kathmandu on Thursday.

PM'S EARNEST CALL TO COMPLY WITH CONSTITUTION

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 25

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has called it incumbent upon all state organs and stakeholders to adhere to the constitution and institutionalise the federal democratic republican system.

Meeting with office bearers of the Former Judges' Society at his official residence in Baluwatar on Thursday, PM Prachanda worried about "entities seeking to disturb social harmony and labelling even good deeds as bad" and emphasised the important role former judges had in enforcing the constitution and other laws.

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Today's Supplement Highlight

Arunachal: Bridging cultures, fostering prosperity.



Informal economy in Nepal stands at 42.66% of GDP: Study

BY MODNATH DHAKAL
Kathmandu, Jan. 25

A recent study by the Central Department of Economics of the Tribhuvan University (TU) has estimated the size of Nepal's informal economy at 42.66 per cent of the Gross Domestic Product (GDP) in the Fiscal Year 2020/21.

The size of Nepali economy then was Rs. 3943 billion. It means according to the estimates, economic and business transactions of about Rs. 1682 billion were done informally that particular year. Had all the economic activities been formal, the size of GDP then would have been Rs. 5625 billion which is larger than the current size of economy. The government estimates have maintained that the size of economy in the last FY 2022/23 would be Rs. 5381 billion.

According to Prof. Dr. Shiva Raj Adhikari, Head of the Department, this study presents the potential scope of the informal economy in Nepal using national accounts and Currency Demand Approach.

The report is jointly prepared by Prof. Adhikari and Dr. Nirmal Kumar Raut, Associate Professor of the Department.

According to the National Accounts Approach (NAA), the average size of informal economy in 2020/21 is 38.6 per cent while the CDA puts it at 41.31 per cent.

However, these approaches have shown opposite trend in terms of the expansion of informal economic activities. The NAA has shown that the size of informal economy has come down to 38.60 per cent of the GDP in 2020/21 from 49.10 per cent in 2010/11. This approach has also shown that the informal activities have increased in the previous two fiscal years and went up from 37.60 per cent in 2018/19. But CDA estimated that the size of informal economy has gone up to 41.31 per cent of the GDP in 2020/21 from 35.52 per cent a decade ago.

The study conducted by the Department estimated that the real estate sector was astonishingly highly informal. About 99.97 per cent of the real estate economy, which is Nepal's third-largest contributor to the economy, is informal. It accounted for 9.43 per cent of the GDP in 2020/21.

This industry includes real estate activities involving owned or leased property, fee or contract real estate activities, and owner-occupied dwelling services. "Because of its nature, most of the share is owner-occupied dwelling service, which is treated as informal," read the study.

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Informal Economy by Sectors (Average 2010/11-2020/21)

Sectoral Classification	Share of Informal Economy (% of GDP)
Agriculture forestry and fishing	96.48
Mining and quarrying	4.9
Manufacturing	16.36
Electricity, gas steam and air conditioning supply	14.99
Water supply, sewerage, waste management and remediation activities	2.14
Construction	16.26
Wholesale and retail trade; repair of motor vehicles and motorcycles	14.87
Transportation and storage	0.63
Accommodation and food services activities	50.42
Information and communication services activities	0.13
Finance and insurance activities	0.11
Real estate activities	99.97
Professional scientific and technical activities	3.10
Administrative and support service activities	8.66
Public administration and defense; compulsory social security	0.00
Education	0.19
Health and social work	0.33
Arts, entertainment and recreation etc.	33.69

Source: Size of informal economy in Nepal

Ruling parties win 18 NA seats, UML gets 1

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 25



PHOTO: RSS

Krishna Prasad Sitaula of Koshi Province receiving certificate of wining National Assembly member in Biratnagar on Thursday evening.

Ruling parties won 18 of the 19 seats of the National Assembly in the election held on Thursday.

All candidates from the ruling parties were elected to the National Assembly (NA) from six of seven provinces. However, one candidate from the ruling coalition suffered defeat in Koshi.

Krishna Sitaula of the Nepali Congress was elected from Koshi to the NA as a candidate of the ruling parties, Champa Devi Karki of the ruling CPN (Maoist Centre) lost the election to the UML candidate Rukmani Koirala.

According to the Election Commission, Sitaula won the election with 5,292 votes while his rival Uddhav Paudel of the Rastriya Prajatantra Party got 4,562 votes. Similarly, Koirala garnered 5,086 votes and her closed rival Karki got 4,992 votes.

In Madhes Province, Aananda Prasad Dhungan and Puja Chaudhary from the ruling coalition won the NA election.

According to a statement issued by the Election Commission on Thursday night, NC's Dhungana was elected with 7,370 votes. Likewise, Chaudhary of the Janata Samajwadi Party-Nepal was elected with 7,923 votes.

In Bagmati Province, all four candidates of the ruling coalition were elected. NC's Jeet Jung Basnet from others category was elected by garnering 6, 531 votes, NC's Bishnu Devi Pudasaini from women category was elected with 6,622 votes, CPN (Maoist Centre)'s Shree Krishna Prasad Adhikari from the disabled category was elected with 6,383 votes and CPN (Unified Socialist)'s Ghana Shyam Rijal from Dalit category was elected with 6,512 votes.

Basnet defeated CPN-UML's Trilochan Nirmal Paudel (2,359 votes) and Pudasaini defeated CPN-UML's Roch Kumari Chaulagai (2,552 votes). Similarly, Adhikari got 6,383 votes and his closest rival CPN-UML's Bibek Devkota got 2,734 votes. Rijal's closest rival CPN-UML's Dhurba Raj Bishwokarma got 3,052 votes.

In Gandaki Province, Manrupa Sharma, Kiram Babu Shrestha and Padam Bahadur Pariyar of the ruling coalition won the election. Contested from the women category, Sharma of the CPN (Maoist Centre) secured 3,660 votes. Likewise, Shrestha contested from the other category and Pariyar from the disabled category got 3,808 and 3,774 votes respectively.

In Lumbini Province, both the candidates of the ruling coalition got victory in the election. Bishnu Kumari Sapkota of the Nepali Congress won from the women's category and Jhakku Prasad Subedi of the CPN (Maoist Centre) won from other category securing equal 5,435 votes.

In Karnali Province, all three candidates from the ruling coalition won the election. Krishna Bahadur Rokaya of the Nepali Congress, Sabitri Malla of CPN (Unified Socialist) and Bishnu BK of CPN (Maoist Centre) were elected by garnering 3,870 votes, 3,719 votes and 3,817 votes respectively.

In Sudurpashchim Province, ruling coalition candidates Baldev Bohara and Narayan Datta Bhatta of the Nepali Congress and Renu Chand of CPN (Maoist Centre) won the election by securing 4,328, 4,419 and 4,453 votes respectively.

Eight ruling parties including the NC, Maoist Centre, CPN (Unified Socialist), Janatasamajwadi Party-Nepal, Janamat Party, Loktantrik Samajwadi Party, Rastriya Janamorcha and Nagarik Unmukti Party have forged electoral alliance by fielding common candidates. Likewise, UML and RPP have forged alliance in Koshi.

According to the EC, the elections were held peacefully in all provinces nationwide. The voters' turnout was 99.32 per cent. It said that 546 out of 549 Provincial Assembly members and 1486 out of 1447 chiefs and deputy chiefs of the local levels cast their votes in the election.

The EC informed that in Koshi the voters' turnout was 99.27 per cent while it was 99.73 per cent in Madhes. Out of 366 voters, 364 had cast votes there.

Likewise, 373 of 374 voters cast their votes in Madhes Province with voters' turnout at 99.73 per cent. In Bagmati Province, 98.56 per cent, 342 of 347 voters, cast their votes.

Similarly, in Gandaki Province voters' turnout was 99.57 per cent. Out of 230 voters 229 cast their votes.

Lumbini Province, Karnali Province and Sudurpaschim Province observed 99.34 per cent, 100 per cent and 98.68 per cent voters' turnout respectively.

In Lumbini 303 out of 305 voters, in Karnali all 196 voters and in Sudurpaschim 225 out of 228 voters cast their votes.

The EC has thanked all the political parties, their candidates, representatives, security bodies, employees and the media for their cooperation to conduct the election in a fair, free and peaceful way.

With Thursday's election, CPN (Maoist Centre) has become the largest party in the Upper House with 17 members and the NC second largest party with 16 members.

Congress with community campaign from tomorrow

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 25

In a bid to foster direct engagement with the public, the Nepali Congress has officially announced the initiation of the 'Community Congress' campaign, set to run from January 27 to February 9.

The primary objective of this campaign is to connect with local communities, gather citizens' expectations, suggestions, and concerns, assess the status of service delivery at the grassroots level, and identify successful local practices and development initiatives, according to a statement issued by the party's chief secretary Krishna Prasad Paudel on Thursday.

As part of the campaign strategy, a central committee member has been deployed at every district level. Working in tandem with the members, party leaders will be designated in all 6,743 wards by January 29, as decided by the district working committee.

Party leaders are anticipated to actively participate in various locations during the campaign. Emphasising a community-focused approach, the campaign will refrain from formal programmes such as speeches and seating arrangements, aligning with the overarching goal of listening to the public, read the statement.

The inaugural phase of the campaign is slated to commence on January 30, coinciding with Martyrs' Day, featuring a special programme exclusively held in all 6743 wards. On this day, central committee members, along with members of the Nepali Congress at different levels, will engage in various labour and social activities within their respective wards. The campaign's first phase is scheduled to conclude on February 9, marking Sushil Koirala Memorial Day.

In outlining the programme format, the Nepali Congress urges its members and affiliated organisations to actively participate and contribute to the success of the Community Congress campaign.

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Tribeni Dham gaining popularity among visitors

BY MEENA KANDEL
Kawasoti, Jan. 25

Triveni Dham in East Nawalparasi, well-regarded for its religious, historical and touristic significance, is gaining popularity among visitors.

Also known as Gajendra Moksha Dham, it holds high religious importance, similar to Prayag in India, as a centre of faith and belief. According to religious beliefs, bathing in the confluence of three rivers at Triveni bestows merit and leads to salvation.

Located 25 km south-east from Bardaghat Bazar in West Nawalparasi and 15 km south from Dumkibas in East Nawalparasi, this Dham has recently become a popular destination for both domestic and foreign tourists. However, the livelihood of fishermen who operate boats in Triveni has become risky, forcing them to seek alternative professions.

For the past two decades, it has been Rambris Sahani's routine to arrive at Triveni Dham early in the morning and only return after sunset. Despite his age, his energy remains like that of a young man. Sahani, who has been operating a boat in Triveni, noted a decline in the number of people using boat rides in recent times.



PHOTO: MEENA KANDEL/TRN

Boatman Rambris Sahani waits for passengers at Tribeni Dham, Nawalparasi East.

He said, "We belong to the caste of boatmen. My father learned from my grandfather, and I learned from my father. It is an occupation we have been involved in since childhood." He has spent his life navigating boats on this river. "You have to work until you die," he added.

"In the past, boatmen transported goods from here. We used to deliver salt and kerosene to various cities across the country via Devghat and Narayanghat. Upon returning, we brought back household essentials like pulses, rice, fruits, and sweets. It used to yield a good income," he said.

Now our livelihood is in crisis, Sahani said. With the construction of highways and bridges spanning various points over the river, the number of people opting for boat rides has decreased. He also expressed concern that his livelihood might come to an end with the construction of a suspension bridge.

Radheswar Sahani, another boatman at Triveni, follows a similar routine. He spends his days busy on the riverbank, rowing a boat from morning till evening. Radheswar said that in the past, Triveni used to have 15 to 20 boats, but now there are only nine boats left.

"Nothing remains as it was before, everything is changing. But here we are, waiting on the riverbank for passengers to board our boats," he said. During the Maghe Aausi Mela, devotees from Bihar and Uttar Pradesh of India, and various places in Nepal come here to bathe and take a boat ride on the Narayani River to visit Rishi Balmiki's Ashram inside the Chitwan National Park for worship.

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Country needs to shift focus from trade to production, says Secretary Ghimire

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 25



PHOTO: TRN

Revenue Secretary at the Ministry of Finance Dr. Ram Prasad Ghimire expressing his view that the need for moving from a trade-oriented economy to a production-oriented one is necessary for the sustainability of the national economy in Kathmandu, Thursday.

Revenue Secretary at the Ministry of Finance Dr. Ram Prasad Ghimire has stressed on the need for moving from a trade-oriented economy to a production-oriented one for the sustainability of the national economy.

"Currently, our economy is based on trade, especially imports, which is not helpful in the long run for the country's economy. So, we have to focus on increasing production and exports. The government is ready to facilitate it," he said while addressing a function organised by Nepal Chamber of Commerce (NCC) on the occasion of 72nd International Customs Day Wednesday.

Stating that the signs of improvement have been seen in the economy recently, he said that the businessmen should focus on production enhancement by increasing their investment.

He said that the government has been reforming customs administration and improving infrastructure to facilitate the trade.

He asked the NCC to provide suggestions regarding customs incorporating the problems faced in customs by small as well as big traders.

On the occasion, director general of the Department of Customs Shovakanta Poudel said that the Department has been reforming the customs administration based on the suggestions given by the businessmen and as per the international standards.

He expressed his commitment to take up the suggestions made by the private sector to make the customs administration sound and scientific.

NCC president Rajendra Malla said that trade should be facilitated so as to promote exports and discourage imports.

He emphasised that the transaction value should be recognised in customs evaluation rather than the reference value.

According to Malla, revenue mobilisation will improve only if the customs administration is improved.

He said, "Customs procedures should be facilitated and high-level quarantine measures should be managed in all customs."

Malla emphasised that exportable items should be identified and promoted to reduce trade deficit.

He said that due to Nepal's open borders, smuggling is increasing so the customs administration should be vigilant to control it.

He said that the revenue target should be met by widening the tax net instead of increasing tax rates.

On the occasion, the NCC honoured director of the Department of Customs Harihar Paudel. The Chamber honored director Paudel recognising his service in the Department of Customs.

The Chamber has been honouring one of the best employees of the Department of Customs every year.

CHINESE BANKS PROVIDE 10 TRILLION YUAN IN LOANS FOR PROPERTY SECTOR

XINHUA
Beijing, Jan. 25

China's banking sector provided nearly 10 trillion yuan (1.41 trillion U.S. dollars) in loans to the property sector in 2023, government data showed Thursday.

In breakdown, loans for property development stood at 3 trillion yuan, while those for individual mortgage loans stood at 6.4 trillion yuan, Xiao Yuanqi, deputy head of the National Financial Regulatory Administration, said at a press conference held in Beijing.

Banks' investment in bonds issued by real estate companies reached 427.5 billion yuan as of the end of 2023, representing an increase of 15 percent from a year earlier, Xiao said.

Meanwhile, banks' investment in bonds issued by real estate companies reached 427.5 billion yuan as of the end of 2023, representing an increase of 15 percent from a year earlier, Xiao said.

The official added that the government agency will guide financial institutions to make full use of existing support policies to provide better services for the real estate market and maintain the stability of credit lines to the sector amid its efforts to promote the stable and sound development of the real estate market.

NOKIA SALES, PROFIT DROP

AP
Helsinki, Jan. 25

Nokia on Thursday reported a double-digit decline in sales and a fall in profit in the last three months of 2023, with the wireless and fixed-network equipment maker saying operators are cutting back on investments into 5G and other technology because of economic uncertainty.

The Espoo, Finland-based company reported net profit of 568 million euros ($619 million) for the October-to-December quarter, down from 929 million euros in the same period a year earlier.

Nokia is one of the world's main suppliers of 5G, the latest generation of broadband technology, along with Sweden's Ericsson, China's Huawei and South Korea's Samsung.

Nokia's net income attributable to shareholders came in at 558 million euros in the fourth quarter, down from 931 million euros the previous year. Nokia's sales also fell 23%, to 5.7 billion euros from 7.5 billion euros.

"In 2023 we saw a meaningful shift in customer behaviour impacting our industry driven by the macro-economic environment and high interest rates," CEO Pekka Lundmark said in a statement.

He also pointed to the effect of Nokia's clients such as telecom operators that have already bought new equipment and don't intend to get more.

"Looking ahead, we expect the challenging environment of 2023 to continue during the first half of 2024, particularly in the first quarter," he said. "However, we are now starting to see some green shoots on the horizon" including improved order intake for Nokia's network infrastructure unit.

In October, Nokia announced plans to cut up to 14,000 jobs to reduce costs. It said the measure was needed to enable Nokia to navigate in a weak market environment where low economic growth and high interest rates have put investments by clients on hold.

Other tech companies, such as online retailer eBay on Wednesday, are laying off workers and have pointed to the challenging economy, which has slowed following rapid interest rate hikes unleashed by central banks around the world to combat soaring inflation.

Bhairahawa Customs Office way below its annual revenue target

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Bhairahawa, Jan. 25

Bhairahawa Customs Office, Rupandehi has collected only 30 per cent of the annual target revenue in six months of the current fiscal year 2023/24.

The Customs Office has collected revenue of Rs. 39.14 billion during the first six months of the current fiscal year. This is only 30.62 per cent of the annual revenue collection target.

For the current fiscal year, the Department of Customs has given a target of collecting Rs. 127.83 billion revenue to the Bhairahawa Customs Office. The Customs Office had a target to collect revenue of Rs. 63.10 billion during the first six months of the current fiscal year.

Chief Customs Officer of the Office Narad Gautam said that only 30 per cent revenue of the total annual target was collected in the first six months of the current fiscal year as revenue collection was less in the month of Mangsir and Poush than the other months.

The Customs Department had reduced the revenue collection target for the Bhairahawa Customs Office for the current fiscal year after it collected only 49.41 per cent of the annual revenue target of Rs. 155.60 billion in the last fiscal year.

Although the Department set a reduced target as compared to last year, looking at the volume of revenue collection in six months, it is a challenge for the customs office to meet the target even in the current fiscal year.

According to Chief Customs Officer Gautam, the revenue collection in the first three months of the fiscal year was good, but in October, November and December, the revenue collection was relatively poor.

In the first month (Shrawan) of the current fiscal year, the Office collected revenue of Rs. 6.49 billion. The Office collected the lowest revenue of Rs. 4.49 billion in the month of Kartik against the target of Rs. 10.67 billion.

Similarly, the Office collected 66.94 per cent revenue of the target in the month of Bhadra, 73.31 per cent in the month of Ashoj and 57.96 per cent in the month of Poush.

The Customs Office had been collecting more revenue than the target until the fiscal year 2016/17. Since then, the Office collected 113 per cent of the target in 2020/21 but has not been able to meet the target in any other year.

In the last fiscal year 2022/23, the revenue collection was only 49.41 per cent, lowest in the last eight years.

In terms of amount, about Rs. 4 billion more revenue was collected in the first six months of the current fiscal year as compared to corresponding period last fiscal year.

The Office had collected revenue of Rs. 35.44 billion during the first six months of the last fiscal year.

According to Gautam, the target set by the Department has not been met due to reduced imports passing through the Belahiya border.

According to the Office, the import of items which are imported in largest volume in the past years and the main contributors to the revenue collection has been low in recent years, and the revenue collection has dropped sharply.

Halesi Tuwachung Municipality farmers produce 38 ton peanuts

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Khotang, Jan. 25



PHOTO: TRN

A farmer in Halesi Tuwachung Municipality shows peanuts produced in her own farm.

More than 37 tonnes of peanuts have been produced in one local level of Khotang.

In Halesi Tuwachung Municipality of the district, 37.92 tonnes of peanuts were produced in the current fiscal year 2023/24.

Peanuts have been produced in most of the wards of the municipality.

This year, farmers planted peanuts in an area of 48.85 hectares of land across the municipality. In return 37.92 tonnes of peanuts were produced, said Raju Sah, coordinator of the agriculture section of the municipality.

He said that the market for peanuts is also good, so the farmers make a significant income.

Farmers are selling peanuts using the Pathi in Khotang. According to the farmers, they are being sold at Rs. 300 to Rs. 350 per Pathi.

According to Sah, one tonne of peanuts equals 660 Pathi.

As per the peanut production of this year, farmers have sold peanuts worth Rs. 7.5 million, according to the municipality.

Traders have reached the farmers' houses to buy peanuts.

Most of the peanuts produced by the farmers of Halesi area are bought by local and outsider traders and taken to Halesi market, Diktel, Maghe Sankranti Mela, Barahapokhari Mela, Okhaldhunga and other markets of the district.

Among the ten local levels of the district, peanuts have been cultivated for a long time only in Halesi Tuwachung Municipality.

According to local residents, devotees and pilgrims who come to Halesi, a popular shrine among the Hindus, Buddhists and Kirants, buy peanuts mostly as a gift.

Mayor of Halesi Tuwachung Municipality Bimala Rai said that it was planned to sell peanuts produced in most areas of the municipality by branding them from next year.

The municipality is also conducting a promotion programme for peanuts.

Florida to ban social media accounts for children

AP
Tallahassee, Fla., Jan. 25

Florida children under the age of 16 would be banned from popular social media platforms regardless of parent approval under a bill passed by the House on Wednesday, a measure that is the top priority for the chamber's speaker.

The bill doesn't list which platforms would be affected, but it targets any social media site that tracks user activity, allows children to upload material and interact with others and uses addictive features designed to cause excessive or compulsive use. The bill would not affect apps used for private messages between individuals.

"They're taking advantage of kids growing up. That's their business model. And why do they do it? To keep them hooked ... with the dopamine hits that the platform gives our children with every autoplay, with every like, with every push notification," said bill sponsor Republican Rep. Tyler Sirois.

The House voted 106-13 for the bill, with several Democrats joining Republicans in support. Proponents argued that social media exposes children to bullying and sexual predators and can lead to depression, suicide and an addictive obsession.

Democratic Rep. Michele Rayner said she posted her position on the bill on X on Tuesday, and she referred to her deceased mother. On the House floor Wednesday, she read some of the hateful comments she received from the platform's users, including people who posted, "Your mother sucks" and "Your mom was stupid."

Meta, the company that owns Facebook, Instagram and other social media platforms, urged the House to seek another solution, such as requiring parental approval to download apps. It also wants the issue addressed on a federal level rather than a patchwork of different state laws.

Other states have considered similar legislation, but most have not proposed a total ban. In Arkansas, a federal judge blocked enforcement of a law in August that required parental consent for minors to create new social media accounts.

But Republican House Speaker Paul Renner, who has made the issue his top priority, said the Florida bill should withstand constitutional scrutiny because it targets the addictive features of social media, and not the content.

"It's a situation where kids can't stay off the platforms, and as a result of that, they have been trapped in an environment that harms their mental health," Renner told reporters after the vote.

The Florida bill would require social media companies to close any accounts it believes to be used by minors and to cancel accounts at the request of a minor or parents. Any information pertaining to the account must be deleted.

Opponents argued that the bill would violate the First Amendment and take away benefits some children get from social media. And they said parents should make the decisions on which sites their children can visit.

Democratic Rep. Anna Eskamani said social media was an outlet and comfort where she could find support after her mother died when she was 13.

Myagdi's Khopra Lek receives first snowfall



PHOTO: THAKUR PRASAD ACHARYA\TRN

Snow covered Khopra Lekh of Myagdi which is situated at a height of 3,660 meters.

BY THAKUR PRASAD ACHARYA
Myagdi, Jan. 25

Khopra Lek, a tourist spot located in Annapurna Rural Municipality-5 of Myagdi, received its first snowfall on Wednesday.

The Khopra Lekh, situated at a height of 3,660 meters, was covered in snow for the first time this year.

The views of Dhaulagiri, Nilgiri, Annapurna, Gurja, and other mountains seen from this point were enhanced by the snowfall, adding to their beauty.

This is the first time the area received snowfall, and the surrounding mountains and hills are also concealed in snow said Adesh Tilija, an employee at the Khopra Community Lodge.

After the snowfall, the weather has turned very cold, he added. Gurja, Churen, Nilgiri, Annapurna, and other mountains can be seen right in front of Khopra Lek.

In addition to Khopra, other renowned tourist destinations in Myagdi, such as Khayer Lekh, Ghodepani, Poon Hill, and Moharedanda, have also received snowfall.

The farmers are delighted with the snowfall after a prolonged period of drought.

Similarly, residents have reported snowfall in Gurja, Lulang, Malkbang, Kuinemangale, Chimkhola, Thadakhani, Kuinekhani, Nangi, Sikh, and other settlements.

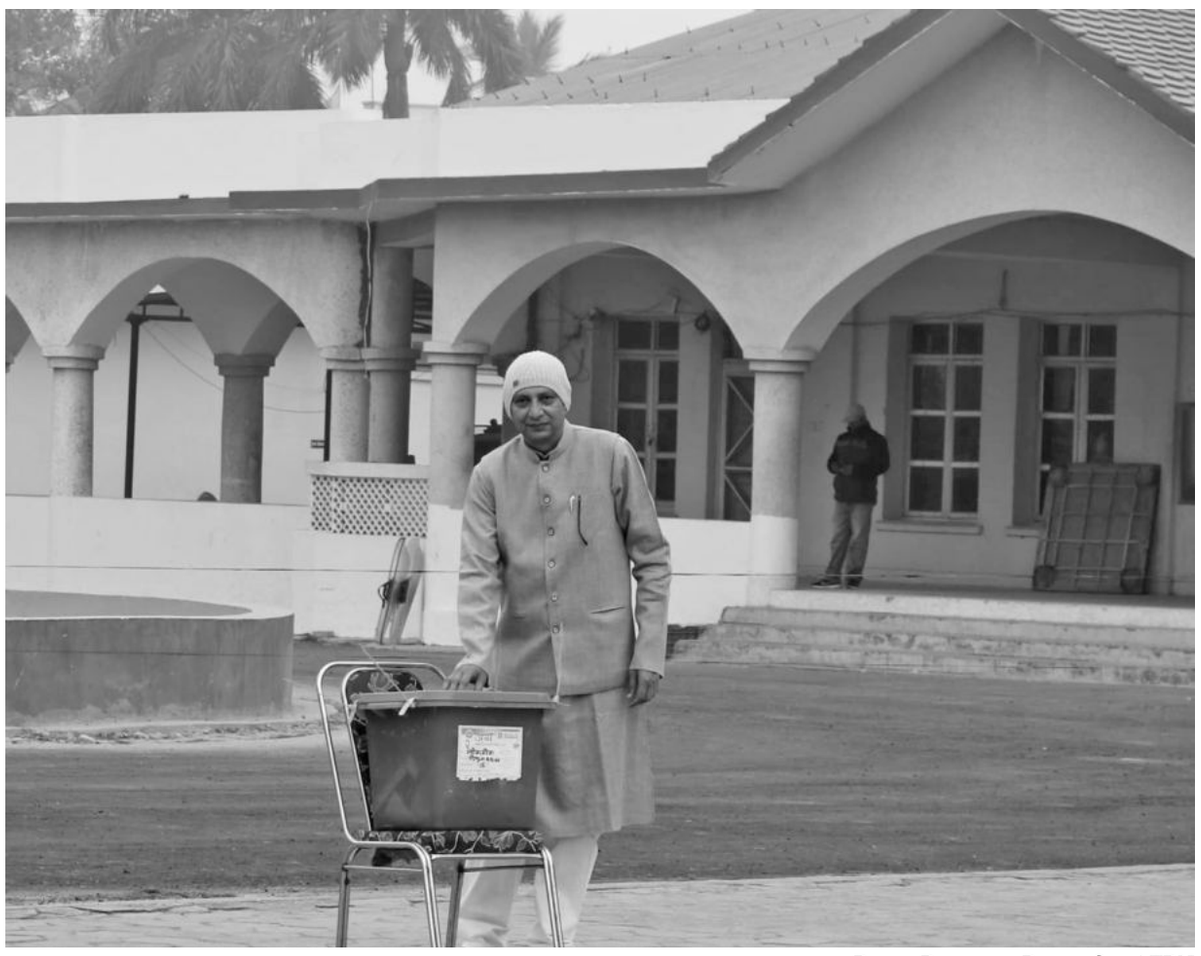


PHOTO: DHIRENDRA PRASAD SHAH\TRN

Madhes Province Chief Minister Saroj Kumar Yadav casting vote in the National Assembly election in Janakpur on Thursday.

Patan High Court upholds District Court order on 60-kg gold smuggling case



BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 25

The Patan High Court has upheld the verdict of the Kathmandu District Court in the 60.716 kg gold smuggling case ordering the continuation of the jail sentence for the 12 accused.

However, it ordered to release six others on bail.

A joint bench of Justices Dhir Bahadur Chand and Krishna Ram Koirala announced the verdict on Wednesday, according to spokesperson and deputy registrar of the High Court Tirtha Raj Bhattarai on Thursday.

The High Court supported the verdict delivered by the Kathmandu District Court issued on October 6, 2023, against Dawa Chhiring, Thumin Chhiring, Shiv Kumar Sarraf, Harkraj Rai, Dilip Bhujel, Ram Kumar Bhujel, Rajendra Kumar Rai, Suman Kharel, Kishore Basnet, Saroj Shrestha, Kumar Dhakal and Santosh Chand.

However, the High Court has revoked the detention order of the defendants Krishna Kumar Shrestha, Pushkar Raj Bhatta, Ganesh Prasad Paudel, Birendra Nepali, Sudarshan Gautam and Yadav Parajuli and gave the order to release them on bail. They are asked to deposit bail amounts from Rs. 100,000 to Rs. 500,000.

A joint bench of Justices Dhir Bahadur Chand and Krishna Ram Koirala announced the verdict on Wednesday, according to spokesperson and deputy registrar of the High Court Tirtha Raj Bhattarai on Thursday.

Although the Central Investigation Bureau (CIB) of Nepal Police had initially implicated 50 individuals in the case, the District Public Prosecutor's Office in Kathmandu proceeded with charges against 29 people.

The TIA's Customs Office has seized the gold on July 18 which was initially said to be one quintal.

A total of 32 individuals were apprehended during the investigation, with the CIB recommending not to charge six of those arrested.

NC Syangja honours democracy warriors



PHOTO: TRN

Former Prime Minister and NC president Sher Bahadur Deuba honouring eight individuals of Syanja district who fought for democracy and people's rights during the democratic movements of 1951, 1990, and 2006.

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Waling, Jan. 25

The Syangja chapter of the Nepali Congress (NC) has honoured various personalities who contributed to political transformation and establishment of democracy in the country on the occasion of its first district convention.

The party's national President and former Prime Minister Sher Bahadur Deuba honoured eight individuals who fought for democracy and people's rights during the democratic movements of 1951, 1990 and 2006.

The party felicitated 96-year-old Bholanath Lamsal, 87-year-old Tarapati Subedi, 86-year-old Bed Prasad Paneru, 82-year-old Bishwo Prem Adhikari, 80-year-old Narsingh Thakuri, 74-year-old Khagendra Raj Regmi, 74-year-old Shalik Ram Neupane and 74-year-old Shree Prasad GT. They were feted as democratic warriors.

36,983 children in Karnali out of school



BY LALIT BASEL
Surkhet, Jan. 25

In Karnali Province, 7 per cent of the children eligible to attend school are out of school.

A report on the status of children attending schools revealed that out of 517,520 children aged between four and 17 years in Karnali, only 482,537 students were enrolled in schools.

According to the survey conducted by the Ministry of Education, Science and Technology, Centre for Education and Human Resource Development (CEHRD), United Nations Children's Fund (UNICEF) and Global Action Nepal, 36,983 children were still not enrolled in the school.

While making public the report, CEHRD director Neelkantha Dhakal said that those not having access to school education should be brought to schools.

According to the report, out of 36,367 children under four, 2,764 (7.6 %) were still not enrolled in schools. Similarly, 10,619 (5.9 %) children out of 191,718 children aged between five and nine years, 8,212 (6.7 %) are out of school.

Among 121,819 children aged between 10 and 12 years studying at grades six to eight, 3,312 (3.8 %) children are out of school.

Among 83,553 children aged between 13 and 14 years and studying in grades nine and ten, 3312 students (3.8%) are out of school.

Likewise, among 93,063 children aged between 15-17 and studying in grades 11 and 12, 12,076 (13%) students were not attending school.

The study also highlighted the risks associated with dropping out of school in Karnali, where basic-level schools faced a 16.5 per cent dropout, lower secondary-level schools faced a 23 per cent risk of dropping out and secondary-level schools faced a 78 per cent risk of dropping out of school.

Director Dhakal said that schools in Karnali faced students dropping out risks due to geographical difficulties, unemployment, poverty, and seasonal migration.

Chief Secretary of Karnali Province Dr. Chudamani Paudel said that it had not been possible to enroll 100 per cent of children at schools due to various reasons.

IGP KUNWAR INSTRUCTS POLICE HOSPITAL DOCTORS TO FOCUS ON QUALITY SERVICE

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 25

Inspector General of Nepal Police (IGP) Basanta Bahadur Kunwar has instructed the doctors of Nepal Police Hospital to work with professional integrity and collective spirit to enhance the image, credibility, trust and quality of hospital service.

IGP Kunwar made this remark while giving instructions to the doctors, health workers and other police personnel working at the Nepal Police Hospital Maharajgunj on Thursday.

He emphasised that the hospital administration should play a more influential role in providing quality services provided by the hospital and managing customer complaints.

IGP Kunwar said that the doctors, health workers and other police personnel working in the hospital should carry out their responsibilities seriously by making proper use of limited resources and focusing on professional interests rather than personal interests.

In the programme, Medical Director and Chief of the Hospital and Additional Inspector General (Technical) Dr. Asha Singh said the administration was always trying to create a working environment with positive thinking to provide a healthy environment and patient-friendly services by adopting the latest technology and methods.

Money for Chaurasi Puja donated to NIC



PHOTO: TRN

Khimananda Poudel and his wife Kaushalya Poudel, residents of Bharatpur Metropolitan City-2, donating Rs. 365,000 to the National Innovation Centre (NIC) on the occasion of their Chaurasi Puja on Thursday.

BY BASANTA PARAJULI
Bharatpur, Jan. 25

A couple from Bharatpur has donated Rs. 365,000 to the National Innovation Centre (NIC) on the occasion of their Chaurasi Puja (a ritual held when one is 84 years old).

Khimananda Poudel and his wife Kaushalya Poudel, residents of Bharatpur Metropolitan City-2, donated the money they would have used for the Puja to the NIC.

They handed over the cheque to the Centre's board member Hari Silwal on Thursday.

Providing the cheque, Khimananda said that they decided to reduce wasteful expenses and support the Centre. Meanwhile, Prem Rimal, his son-in-law, called his parents-in-law's donation a progressive step.

Bikram Pandey, former minister and member of the erstwhile Constituent Assembly, also spoke on the occasion and stressed the need to preserve culture and traditions.

"If we let our culture and traditions disappear, our originality will also disappear," he said.

Everybody present at the Puja wished the Poudel couple a long and healthy life and praised their philanthropy.

THREE DIE OF VIRAL FEVER IN MUGU

RSS
Mugu, Jan. 25

Three people have so far died of viral fever at Purumuru village of Soru Rural Municipality-6 in Mugu. The deceased are identified as Hari Bahadur Shahi (72), Kriti Chhantyal (75) and Kushum Dholi (24), according to a local, Karnajit Bumi.

The prevailing fever is suspected to be viral. The outbreak has affected multiple areas, including Jima, Bhiee, Natharpu, Sipa, Khyalcha, and Bumcha, in addition to Purumuru.

The District Hospital in Mugu is grappling with an influx of patients, and locals have raised concerns about the lack of medical and other support from the government.

Karnajit Bumi expressed the desperation of the people in seeking assistance. Reports indicate that local health posts are running out of essential supplies, including basic medications like paracetamol.

In response to the situation, the District Health Office visited Purumuru and Jima on Tuesday, conducting health checkups for over 150 individuals.

District Hospital's Dr. Kamal Dhungana explained that the viral fever was exacerbated by the increasing cold and it is expected to take some time to bring the situation under control.

Symptoms of fever include continuous sweating, headache, muscle pain, loss of appetite, and fatigue.

THOUGHT FOR TODAY

It is difficult to free fools from the chains they revere.
- Voltaire

EDITORIAL

Productive Investment

Investment is the lifeblood of development. For a developing country like Nepal, investment in infrastructure underpinning sectors like transport, health, education, manufacturing, among others, are critical to infuse a dose of momentum into its economy. To nourish a vibrant economy, it cannot afford to recklessly pour unlimited money into unproductive sectors like real state and share market. There must be solid investment in the components of GDP such as agriculture, industry and services which are not only the productive sectors but also the pillars of the economy. When it comes to investing on these sectors, there must be no ifs and buts on the part of the government.

Duly recognising this need, Finance Minister Dr. Prakash Sharan Mahat has stressed the need for moving in the direction of getting more returns from limited resources citing that the economy has shown unmistakable sign of recovery and has improved significantly this year. He has rightly said that banks and financial institutions should contribute more to economic development by investing in the productive sector.

In the past, there is no denying that a significant chunk of banks' investment didn't go to right places. A lot of credit was extended to the stock market and real estate business. The borrowers who took loans at that time are now in trouble because the interest rate has substantially increased but there is zero or little return from the investment to pay back the loan. The crisis facing cooperatives mirrors this colossal problem – a reminder of what will happen when unrestraint investment in made in unproductive sector like real estate.

There is no option to increasing investment in sectors that not only creates and sustains jobs but also generates revenue. Doing so is crucial to strengthen the middle-class and to build a foundation for long-term economic prosperity. Also necessary is stopping easy credit and frenzied investment in real state that only creates a huge bubble in the prices of property and other assets. The minister rightly pointed out that the resources of the state should be invested in the areas that give maximum returns.

In a good move, the central bank, Nepal Rastra Bank, has prioritised a directed loan programme for investment, clearly stipulating that loans should be formally granted to the productive sector. Failure to comply with these instructions may result in penalties. Despite this, banks are showing indifference towards investing in one such sector, agricultural sector, citing associated risk. But agriculture and manufacturing are our strengths. With plenty of arable land and increased power supply, the two productive sectors are in a position to produce foods and goods at an industrial scale so that we not only can substitute imports but can also generate employment opportunities for many. This can go a long way to check the exodus of our frustrated youths who are heading abroad in search of greener pastures in unprecedented numbers.

The monetary policy of the central bank should work to ensure that the sectors get the needed capital boost which is both feasible and a necessity. This is also needed to spur economic activities which will go on to create an environment conducive for the creation of prosperity as well as the middle class who can increase the demand of finished products by consuming them.

New Road Turns 'No Parking' Zone

BINI DAHAL

Urban planning will always be a matter of concern for Kathmandu as the capital city is among the most unplanned cities worldwide. However, the city is well-known for providing a myriad of opportunities for people living across the country. While saying this, it is worth mentioning that the city is also characterised by its overcrowding and parking issues.

Over the years, the Kathmandu Metropolitan City (KMC) and its successive leaderships have tried to improve the situation. But there are too many stumbling blocks that prevent any changes from happening. Any ad hoc action from the side of the authority is met with criticism and most of the times, it is blamed for not understanding the different perspectives of different stakeholders.

And in recent times, the leadership of Mayor Balen Shah has been both appreciated and criticised. Shah has been working hard to ensure that the roads are open enough so that pedestrians can walk freely. His latest step has been to make New Road, a commercial area located in the heart of Kathmandu, a no-vehicle zone.

As part of this initiative, the KMC is working on clearing roads and removing parking areas from New Road. The authority has already placed no-parking signs at major locations such as Dharmapath, Mahabauddha, Khichapokhari and Bir Hospital. For now, it is requesting for compliance. Plans are on cards to take action if people keep on parking their vehicles at the restricted areas. The local government has also proposed to widen the footpaths and reduce the width of the main roads.

However, business community people in New Road are protesting and blaming the authority for making such drastic decisions without taking their opinion into account. They are concerned that making the area a no-parking zone will negatively affect their business and ultimately the government's ability to collect enough revenue. The authority has mentioned that businessmen should manage parking for their customers by themselves. And this has further agitated the businessmen. The metropolis has asked people to make use of the Kathmandu Tower, located at Old Bus Park, for parking purposes.

New Road is popular as a shopping getaway for most of Kathmandu denizens. Therefore, it is always heavily packed with people and vehicles. Commuting around is very difficult. The KMC's decision to ensure greater urban mobility is understandable. From its perspective, it is trying its best for improvements. But from the businessmen's viewpoint, the KMC's action could harm their business. We will only be able to analyse if businesses will go down or not after the decision is fully implemented. But, there is also a view that clearing roads and improving mobility can further increase the number of customers.

Amidst these differing views, the authority and the businessmen should come together and find a solution to the problem. Rather than having a direct negative outlook, analysing the pros and cons of this step should be taken into consideration. The metropolis area is already overcrowded and urban management seems to be an essential responsibility of the authority. Businessmen and other stakeholders should comply with and support the authority in its undertakings.

But while saying that, consensus should be built and taking precautionary measures is also equally important. The authorities should not leave the businessmen helpless. Their voices should also be heard at a time when the economic sector has been going through a challenging situation. Positive synergy between the two is the key to enhancing urban mobility in Kathmandu.

NAM For Resilient Global Order



Dr. Narad Bharadwaj

The 19th summit conference of Non-Aligned Movement (NAM) ended at Kampala, capital of Uganda on 20 January with consensus on reinventing the relevance of the movement but clueless about how to restructure its operational framework to enable it to address multi-polar geo-political realities. NAM had come into existence in September 1961, just one year before the Cuban missile crisis of 1962, as a response to the challenges emanating from the bipolar world order. This movement, which remained a powerful alternative framework for handling global affairs more than five decade, is now at its lowest ebb.

During its heydays, the NAM worked as an effective alternative foreign policy tool to navigate a safe passage through the labyrinth of tricks and truculence resorted to by superpowers and their allies to sustain their global dominance and monopolise resources. During the Cold War period, the NAM stood as a bulwark of peace and neutrality consistently refusing to be part of power alignment and avoiding complicity in inter-state conflict.

Under the leadership of leaders like Gamal Abdul Nasser of Egypt, Jawaharlal Nehru of India, Joseph Broz Tito of Yugoslavia, Sukarno of Indonesia and late King Mahendra of Nepal, the NAM had effectively navigated the harsh terrain of Cold War as a defender of sovereignty of poor developing countries of the world. However, with the departure of its charismatic founding leaders from the global stage, the ship of Non-Aligned Movement became rudderless in the stormy sea of global geo-politics of the ensuing post-Cold War decades.

Multilateralism

During two decades of post-Cold War transition, the NAM suffered a serious decline together with whole range of international institutions that had consistently promoted multilateralism fostering the values of equality, inclusivity and collaboration. During this period, a global surge of democratisation took place under what is often referred to as the Third Wave Democracy. The Rose Revolution in Georgia (2003), Jasmine Revolution in Tunisia (2010) and Arab Spring in West Asia (2011) were much-hyped by western democracies which hardly brought any positive social change except destabilising these countries. Syria, Libya and Yemen are still burning in the racial fire ignited and stoked by these revolutions.

Despite the immense obstacles, NAM was still the most credible institutional movement which rallied hundreds of small and developing countries to pursue a foreign policy based on neutrality, non-alignment, and respect to sovereignty, mutual equality and cooperation. It continued, against all odds, to play an instrumental role in protecting humanity from the horrors of war till early 21st century. The fall of USSR and the rise of unipolarity sounded death knell for multilateral institutions. Institutions like WTO, United Nations, World Bank and IMF all aligned their policies to suit the interest of power countries which funded them or were able to use their economic resources and military might to manipulate their operations against the interest of poor developing countries.

Multilateralism is incompatible with unipolar structure of power. During that period NAM faced various obstacles in the way of institutionalising its vision of equitable, inclusive and peaceful world order due to duress from power blocks and divergent interests of

> In the present day world, where the dark clouds of war are hovering over the sky, NAM can emerge as a relevant and resilient agency.

member states making it difficult for framing consensus. Now the euphoria over the fall of bipolar world has come to an end with the rise of China and the resurgence of Russia as global strategic and economic powers setting stage for multi-polar conflict, and by extension, revival of multilateralism. Multi-polar world order paves the way for the evolution and consolidation of institutions. Diffusion of power and resources help sustain multilateral dynamics.

In the changed context, international institutions, including NAM, must try to reinvent themselves to be able to play their role for fostering collaboration, cooperation, coexistence and consensus. For that purpose there is a need to introduce reform in their structures and build preparedness to cope with the upcoming challenges imposed by the geopolitics pivoting towards multi-polarity. In recent years, we find several countries locked into armed conflict in a number of battle fronts. The Russian-Ukraine war and Israel-Hamas war run the risk of escalating into wider conflict because of superpowers taking sides and supplying lethal weapon systems to their proxies. In such situation, the Non-Aligned Movement has the potential to emerge as a powerful agency to deescalate conflict and find peaceful settlement through dialogue and diplomacy.

Non-Alignment Movement is rooted in the principle of Panchsheel which is also known as five principles of peaceful coexistence. These principles can also be rephrased as the policy of mutual respect to sovereignty and territorial integrity, mutual non-aggression, non-interference in domestic affairs, mutual non-aggression and peaceful coexistence. These are the core values of diplomacy which, if implemented honestly, may help the world to avert violent confrontation and seek settlement of global issues through peaceful dialogue.

As one of the founding members of NAM, Nepal has always played its role responsibly to institutionalise its principles in the directive principles of its foreign policy. The commitment which Nepal has expressed to fulfill its obligation for its continued operation need not be reiterated. As a country navigating a path for survival and growth through treacherous landscape of geopolitics, Non-Aligned Movement is a magical foreign policy tool for safeguarding its vital interest.

Bulwark of peace

During the past six decades of its existence, Non-Aligned Movement stood fast as a bulwark of peace effectively pushing back the forces of aggression addressing regional and global issues through peaceful negotiation and dialogue. During the post-Cold War decades NAM suffered serious decline both in its profile and performances.

The situation is now undergoing change making it difficult for unilateralism to gain currency. Shifting geo-political fault lines are again yielding operational space for multilateralism and peace agencies like NAM. In the present day world, where the dark clouds of war are hovering over the sky, NAM can emerge as a relevant and resilient agency capable of containing violence and preventing war by promoting peace, equality, inclusivity, collaboration and co-existence which are the fundamental prerequisites for just world order.

(The author is former chairperson of Gorkhapatra Corporation and former ambassador of Nepal to Qatar.)

Embracing Neutral Foreign Policy



Lok Deep Thapa

The Non-Aligned Movement or NAM was established barely one decade after the end of the Second World War. Some leaders with much vision and astute maturity on how they could develop their nation without taking any sides were directly involved in this campaign. Credit must go to leaders like the first Prime Minister of India late Jawaharlal Nehru and former President of the then Yugoslavia, late Joseph Tito for establishing this movement. Nepal was also one of the pioneer nations in further strengthening this campaign.

The entire world was in a jittery condition when the devastating World War ended. It was further in trauma when the Western powers led by America and the Eastern powers headed by the then Soviet Union became polarised and ended up in the beginning of the Cold War.

That was the time when many countries suffered from economic woes and only a few seasoned leaders had the vision to lead their nation to economic development without taking any sides in the Cold War among the then two 'super powers' of the world.

Utter necessity

So one can easily imagine the utter necessity like the Non Aligned Movement, especially for the developing countries which wanted to stay independent and not take any sides. Even presently economic giants like China and India, hoped to make their economies stronger by keeping a non-aligned foreign policy. For Nepal also, which was positioned in a difficult geo-political situation, NAM was of importance, if for nothing, in at least keeping intact its independence and sovereignty.

The polarisation we saw in the past is taking place even now, as we have been witnessing hostile activities of one power or the other in many places, including in fragile states in Asia and Africa. At present as per the predictions of noted intellectuals and senior media persons, there has been even more interest in Nepal because of its strategic geographical situation and thus there has been very frequent visits by all levels of foreign officials from different countries to Nepal to promote their own causes. The leaders here have to stay alert so that the country does not fall into a trap of siding with any one power or the other. It is, therefore, that the importance of NAM is even more crucial not only all over the world, but also in tiny Nepal just because of its geo-political importance.

In this context, it was a wise move on the part of Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal Prachanda to go and personally take part in the recently held summit meeting of NAM held in Kampala, the capital city of troubled Uganda in Africa. This scribe remembers the time when he attended the summit meeting of NAM in Bangdung city of Indonesia. This was a historic moment, as the Movement was moved forward from this very City many decades back. It was definitely a rich experience to see many illustrious leaders from many countries in close distance, who had come to attend the meet. This author personally met with the Indian Prime

> It is, therefore, that the importance of NAM is even more crucial not only all over the world, but also in tiny Nepal just because of its geo-political importance.

Minister and also the then Afghani Prime Minister and other leaders, when they freely inter-acted with representatives of the international media during their stay there.

Prime Minister Prachanda called for a peaceful solution to the hostility in the Mideast and he also appealed to the international community to provide help to Nepal in its efforts for development. In fact, many were in praise of the sage manner in which he put forth the drawbacks and needs of different countries of the world while at the same time making a poignant point of Nepal needing the cooperation of the international community in different sectors.

Nepal's PM has made it clear what the country has to do internally and how it has to maintain its international relations. This has to be taken seriously by those decision makers within the country as well as diplomats stationed abroad. Like Prime Minister Narendra Modi of neighbouring India has made a point not only within his country but also internationally by keeping his words with the help of millions Indian citizens living abroad helping him in his causes and also the bureaucracy supporting him, it is necessary for our own political parties and also government workers to support what PM Prachanda is trying to do.

Platform

It is the same with NAM, it provides a platform to the least developed nations and the developing ones, but it is the responsibility of the nations to themselves make life of their citizens better without taking any sides. When the entire world is polarised and under threat, virtually all the people feel very insecure. Right now the relevance of NAM has become even more important because once more we are seeing distinct differences between the major military and economic powers of the world. Nepal too is suffering, not because of a threat of violence, but because young people are abandoning the country for better opportunities abroad. This aspect of a crucial situation has to be also seriously looked into by the government and those who format long term plans for the country.

What the entire world needs right now are prosperity and peace and it is no different with Nepal and many other least developed countries like it. Nobody wants to see the displacement or exodus of its own citizens for different reasons. Now, most nations are seeing the fleeing of people from their own homes and country, mostly because of violence. In Nepal, it is mainly due to economic factors that we are seeing internal migration and also the exodus of young manpower from the country. While it is very pragmatic to be involved in the Non-Aligned Movement, it would also be very prudent to see that the country's citizens also feel secure and be a participant in the prosperity of the nation.

(The author is former chief editor of this daily.)

50 YEARS AGO

THE RISING NEPAL

January 26, 1974

Rice Export To Bangladesh Starts

Jhapa, Jan 24: Rice export from Jhapa to Bangladesh started on Monday, says RSS.

NOTICE TO CONTRIBUTORS

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Or send them to
P.O. Box 23, Kathmandu, Nepal

READER'S MAIL

Promote Clean Energy For Job Creation

This is in reference to a news report *"Jhapa solar plant aiming to attract tourists"* published in your daily on Thursday. According to the news report, a solar power plant located in Jhapa is expected to both generate electricity and attract tourists. The plant is stated to have a capacity of 12 megawatt.

The Nepal Electricity Authority (NEA) is said to be purchasing 10 megawatt electricity at a cost of Rs. 7.3 per unit. Constructed by Jhapa Energy Limited, they plan to develop the location into a solar park by beautifying the area and even constructing a view tower.

This seems to be a really interesting idea. These types of initiatives help create employment opportunities for the local people and also can pose a source of revenue for the government.

For instance, through this initiative, careers like security guards, maintenance officers, tour guides



can be created. At a time where a number of people are headed abroad for jobs, the public and the private sector should work towards creating employment opportunities and retaining workforce starting from the local level.

The private sector should work closely with the local communities in order to facilitate jobs for them.

Kritika Pokharel
Mid Baneshwor, Kathmandu

TAILPIECE

A minister delivered a sermon in 10 minutes one Sunday morning, which was about half the usual length of his sermons. He explained, "I regret to inform you that my dog, who is very fond of eating paper, ate that portion of my sermon which I was unable to deliver this morning."After the service, a visitor from another church shook hands with the preacher and said, "Reverend, if that dog of yours has any pups, I want to give one to my minister."

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After the christening of his baby brother in church, Little Johnny cried all the way home in the back seat of the car. His father asked him what was wrong and finally, the boy sobbed, "That priest said he wanted us brought up in a Christian home, and I want to stay with you guys!"

Qatar lashes out at Premier Netanyahu over remarks

AP
Rafah, Gaza Strip, Jan. 25



PHOTO: AP
Palestinians look at a mosque destrooyed in an Israeli strike in Rafah, Gaza Strip. Wednesday, Jan. 24, 2024.

Qatar said it was appalled Wednesday by leaked remarks made by Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu in which he criticized the country's mediation efforts with Hamas, complicating already arduous negotiations meant to halt the hostilities in exchange for a hostage release.

In a meeting with families of hostages held by Hamas, Netanyahu said Qatar's role in the mediation was "problematic." Qatar, a key mediator that also has deep ties to the militant group and hosts some of its exiled leaders, said Netanyahu's remarks were "irresponsible and destructive."

The public spat came as sensitive talks were underway in an effort to advance a potential agreement that might offer some respite in the devastating 3-month-old war. The fighting has killed more than 25,000 Palestinians, according to the Health Ministry in Hamas-run Gaza, displaced some 85% of the territory's 2.3 million people and triggered a humanitarian catastrophe that has spread hunger, malnutrition and disease across the embattled coastal enclave.

As the diplomacy continued, fierce fighting still raged, especially in southern Gaza, where the United Nations said an Israeli tank strike on a U.N. facility killed at least nine people and wounded dozens.

Netanyahu has vowed to press ahead with the offensive until "complete victory" against Hamas, which started the war with its Oct. 7 assault across the border, killing some 1,200 people in Israel and abducting 250 others.

Israel says it is fighting in self-defense, but it faces charges that it is committing genocide at the U.N. world court at The Hague, which announced that it would issue a decision Friday on South Africa's request for an interim order telling Israel to halt the hostilities.

Qatar has been a critical link in negotiating efforts between Israel and Hamas. In Netanyahu's leaked remarks, which were broadcast Tuesday on Israeli Channel 12 television, he also told the families that he has intentionally not thanked Qatar for its mediation efforts, claiming it could put more pressure on the Islamic militant group.

"Qatar in my opinion is no different, in essence, from the U.N. It is no different, in essence, from the Red Cross, and in some ways it is even more problematic," he said. Israel views those organizations with suspicion, seeing them as biased against it and not helpful enough in securing the hostages' freedom.

Netanyahu also said in the leaked audio that he had expressed anger at the United States for renewing a military base in the Gulf state. He said he told the Americans to put pressure on Qatar to put pressure on Hamas.

Qatar helped secure a weeklong truce in November in which over 100 hostages were released. It also is involved in efforts to broker a new deal to bring home the roughly 130 hostages that remain in captivity.

Qatar, along with Egypt, is working on a new agreement that could set free more hostages. The White House's Middle East envoy, Brett McGurk, was in Doha on Wednesday, National Security Council spokesperson John Kirby said.

Japan's 'Moon Sniper' makes 'pin-point' landing

AFP
Tokyo, Jan. 25

Japan's "Moon Sniper" craft landed around 55 metres (180 feet) from its target, the country's space agency said Thursday as it released the first images from the mission.

The unmanned Smart Lander for Investigating Moon (SLIM), dubbed the "Moon Sniper" for its pin-point technology, had the goal of touching down within 100 metres (330 feet) of a specific landing spot.

That is much more precise than the usual landing zone of several kilometres.

"SLIM succeeded in a pin-point soft landing... the landing point is confirmed to be 55 metres away from the target point," space agency JAXA said.

Saturday's soft lunar landing made Japan only the fifth nation to achieve the feat, after the United States, Soviet Union, China and India.

But celebrations were muted because of a problem with the lightweight spacecraft's solar batteries, which were not generating power.

JAXA decided to switch the craft off with 12 percent power remaining, to allow for a possible recovery when the sun's angle changes.

"If sunlight hits the Moon from the west in the future, we believe there's a possibility of power generation, and we're currently preparing for restoration," JAXA said earlier this week.

Before switching SLIM off, mission control was able to download technical and image data from the craft's descent and the lunar surface.

On Thursday, JAXA published the first colour images from the mission -- showing the SLIM craft sitting intact at a slight angle on the rocky grey surface, lunar slopes rising in the distance.

The mission was aiming for a crater where the Moon's mantle, the usually deep inner layer beneath its crust, is believed to be exposed on the surface.

By analysing the rocks there, JAXA hopes to shed light on the mystery of the Moon's possible water resources, key to building bases there one day as possible stopovers on the way to Mars.

Two probes detached successfully from SLIM on Saturday: one with a transmitter and another designed to trundle around the lunar surface beaming images to Earth.

This shape-shifting mini-rover, slightly bigger than a tennis ball, was co-developed by the firm behind the Transformer toys and took the picture released by JAXA on Thursday.

SLIM is one of several recent lunar missions by governments and private firms, 50 years after the first human Moon landing.

But technical problems are rife, and the United States faced two setbacks this month in its ambitious Moon programmes.

Two previous Japanese lunar missions -- one public and one private -- have also failed.

In 2022, the country unsuccessfully sent a lunar probe named Omotenashi as part of the United States's Artemis 1 mission.

12 KILLED IN TRAFFIC ACCIDENT IN INDIA

XINHUA
New Delhi, Jan. 25

Twelve people were killed Thursday in a collision between an autorickshaw and a speeding container truck in the northern Indian state of Uttar Pradesh, police said. The accident took place in Allahganj area, about 182 km northwest of Lucknow, the capital city of Uttar Pradesh.

"Today late morning, an autorickshaw carrying passengers collided with a container truck ... killing 12 people. The deceased were identified as eight men, three women and one child," a senior police official Ashok Kumar Meena said.

The accident is attributed to low visibility caused by dense fog that engulfed the area in the morning.

Police have registered a case and ordered an investigation to ascertain the cause of the accident. The container truck has been seized, but its driver managed to escape.

"A police team has been formed to arrest the truck driver," the police official said.

Deadly road accidents are common in India due to overloading, bad condition of roads and reckless driving. Around 150,000 people are killed every year in about half a million road accidents across India, officials said.

Sri Lanka passes bill allowing govt to remove online posts

AP
Colombo, Sri Lanka, Jan. 25



PHOTO: AP
Sri Lankan social media activists hold placards with slogans against the proposed Online Safety Bill during a protest near the Parliament in Colombo, Sri Lanka, Tuesday, Jan. 23, 2024.

Sri Lanka's parliament on Wednesday overwhelmingly approved an internet regulation bill that was highly criticized as a move to stifle speech in an election year while the Indian Ocean island nation copes with an economic crisis that required an international bailout.

The Online Safety bill would allow the government to set up a commission with a wide range of powers, which includes ordering people and internet service providers to remove online posts deemed "prohibited statements." It can also legally pursue people who publish such posts.

The government led by President Ranil Wickremesinghe submitted the bill for debate on Tuesday, after which it was passed in the 225-member house, where the ruling coalition enjoys majority. Only 62 lawmakers voted against the bill.

Opposition lawmakers criticized the bill for creating "a very oppressive environment." Media, internet and civil rights groups had asked the government to withdraw the bill, saying it would undermine freedoms.

The New York-based Human Rights Watch said the bill would create a repressive law with broad and vague "speech-related offenses punishable by lengthy prison terms."

The Asia Internet Coalition, which has Apple, Amazon, Google and Yahoo as members, said the bill "would undermine potential growth and foreign direct investment into Sri Lanka's digital economy."

The secretary of the Sri Lanka Professional Web Journalists Association, Kalum Shivantha, said the bill would severely impact how they do their job. "Online journalists might resort to self-censorship and even our news websites might get shut down," he said.

However, Public Security Minister Tiran Alles, who introduced the bill in Parliament, said it would address problems related to online fraud, abuse and false statements that threaten national security and stability.

He said more than 8,000 complaints were filed last year related to online crimes, including sexual abuse, financial scams, cyber harassment, and data theft.

Alles added that the bill was not drafted to harass media or political opponents.

Sri Lanka is still reeling from its worst economic crisis, which hit the island nation two years ago. The country declared bankruptcy in 2022 with more than $83 billion in debt, more than half of it to foreign creditors.

The crisis caused severe shortages of food, fuel and other necessities. Strident public protests led to the ouster of then-President Gotabaya Rajapaksa.

The IMF agreed last year to a $2.9 billion bailout package for the hard-hit country.

After Rajapaksa fled, then-Prime Minister Ranil Wickremesinghe was appointed as president by parliament. The shortages of necessities have largely decreased over the past year, but public dissatisfaction has spiked after the government imposing new high taxes on professionals and businesses and raised energy bills.

Rights groups say Wickremesinghe has moved to stifle dissent, by cracking down on anti-government protests and arresting protestors and activists.

Sri Lanka's presidential election is set to be held later this year.

PRISM

Flight delayed by penguin on runway

Wellington: A plane was delayed at New Zealand's Wellington International Airport due to a well-dressed hazard on the runway: a penguin.

The airport said on social media that the "unusual little visitor" wandered onto the tarmac, leading airport staff scrambling to get the flightless bird to safety.

An airport spokesperson said an Air Chathams flight had been preparing to take off when the blue penguin, or kororā, wandered out onto the runway.

"The pilot and passengers patiently waited while Wellington Airport staff raced out to collect and help the visitor," the post said.

Beaver blamed for Texas road washing

Officials in a Texas county said a beaver was to blame for a neighborhood's main access road being washed away in the rain.

Polk County Emergency Management warned residents on social media that a sizable area of Crystal Lakes West, the main access road for the Crystal Lakes subdivision in Livingston, washed away amid heavy rains.

Polk County Precinct 2 said a beaver dam blocked a pipe in a culvert running underneath the roadway, causing a flood that loosened the dirt and washed the road away.

Officials said the road is being repaired with a dump truck filled with dirt and the process is expected to take up to eight hours.

(AP)

Gene therapy allows kids with inherited deafness to hear

AFP
Shanghai, Jan. 25



PHOTO: AP
In this image from video provided by the Children's Hospital of Philadelphia, an 11-year-old boy who was born with hereditary deafness is given a hearing test in Philadelphia, after he underwent a gene therapy procedure in October 2023.

Gene therapy has allowed several children born with inherited deafness to hear. A small study published Wednesday documents significantly restored hearing in five of six kids treated in China. On Tuesday, the Children's Hospital of Philadelphia announced similar improvements in an 11-year-old boy treated there. And earlier this month, Chinese researchers published a study showing much the same in two other children.

So far, the experimental therapies target only one rare condition. But scientists say similar treatments could someday help many more kids with other types of deafness caused by genes. Globally, 34 million children have deafness or hearing loss, and genes are responsible for up to 60% of cases. Hereditary deafness is the latest condition scientists are targeting with gene therapy, which is already approved to treat illnesses such as sickle cell disease and severe hemophilia.

Children with hereditary deafness often get a device called a cochlear implant that helps them hear sound.

"No treatment could reverse hearing loss … That's why we were always trying to develop a therapy," said Zheng-Yi Chen of Boston's Mass Eye and Ear, a senior author of the study published Wednesday in the journal Lancet. "We couldn't be more happy or excited about the results."

The team captured patients' progress in videos. One shows a baby, who previously couldn't hear at all, looking back in response to a doctor's words six weeks after treatment. Another shows a little girl 13 weeks after treatment repeating father, mother, grandmother, sister and "I love you."

All the children in the experiments have a condition that accounts for 2% to 8% of inherited deafness. It's caused by mutations in a gene responsible for an inner ear protein called otoferlin, which helps hair cells transmit sound to the brain. The one-time therapy delivers a functional copy of that gene to the inner ear during a surgical procedure. Most of the kids were treated in one ear, although one child in the two-person study was treated in both ears.

The study with six children took place at Fudan University in Shanghai, co-led by Dr. Yilai Shu, who trained in Chen's lab, which collaborated on the research. Funders include Chinese science organizations and biotech company Shanghai Refreshgene Therapeutics.

Researchers observed the children for about six months. They don't know why the treatment didn't work in one of them. But the five others, who previously had complete deafness, can now hear a regular conversation and talk with others. Chen estimates they now hear at a level around 60% to 70% of normal. The therapy caused no major side effects.

Preliminary results from other research have been just as positive. New York's Regeneron Pharmaceuticals announced in October that a child under 2 in a study they sponsored with Decibel Therapeutics showed improvements six weeks after gene therapy. The Philadelphia hospital — one of several sites in a test sponsored by a subsidiary of Eli Lilly called Akouos — reported that their patient, Aissam Dam of Spain, heard sounds for the first time after being treated in October. Though they are muffled like he's wearing foam earplugs, he's now able to hear his father's voice and cars on the road, said Dr. John Germiller, who led the research in Philadelphia.

"It was a dramatic improvement," Germiller said. "His hearing is improved from a state of complete and profound deafness with no sound at all to the level of mild to moderate hearing loss, which you can say is a mild disability. And that's very exciting for us and for everyone. "

Columbia University's Dr. Lawrence Lustig, who is involved in the Regeneron trial, said although the children in these studies don't wind up with perfect hearing, "even a moderate hearing loss recovery in these kids is pretty astounding."

Still, he added, many questions remain, such as how long the therapies will last and whether hearing will continue to improve in the kids.

Also, some people consider gene therapy for deafness ethically problematic. Teresa Blankmeyer Burke, a deaf philosophy professor and bioethicist at Gallaudet University, said in an email that there's no consensus about the need for gene therapy targeting deafness. She also pointed out that deafness doesn't cause severe or deadly illness like, for example, sickle cell disease. She said it's important to engage with deaf community members about prioritization of gene therapy, "particularly as this is perceived by many as potentially an existential threat to the flourishing of signing Deaf communities."

TODAY IN HISTORY

661 – The Rashidun Caliphate is effectively ended with the assassination of Ali, the last caliph.
1808 – The Rum Rebellion is the only successful (albeit short-lived) armed takeover of the government in New South Wales.
1837 – Michigan is admitted as the 26th U.S. state.
1841 – James Bremer takes formal possession of Hong Kong Island at what is now Possession Point, establishing British Hong Kong.
1855 – Point No Point Treaty is signed in Washington Territory.
1856 – First Battle of Seattle: Marines from the USS Decatur drive off American Indian attackers after all-day battle with settlers.
1863 – American Civil War: Governor of Massachusetts John Albion Andrew receives permission from the Secretary of War to raise a militia organization for men of African descent.
1870 – Reconstruction Era: Virginia is readmitted to the Union.
1885 – Troops loyal to The Mahdi conquer Khartoum, killing the Governor-General Charles George Gordon.

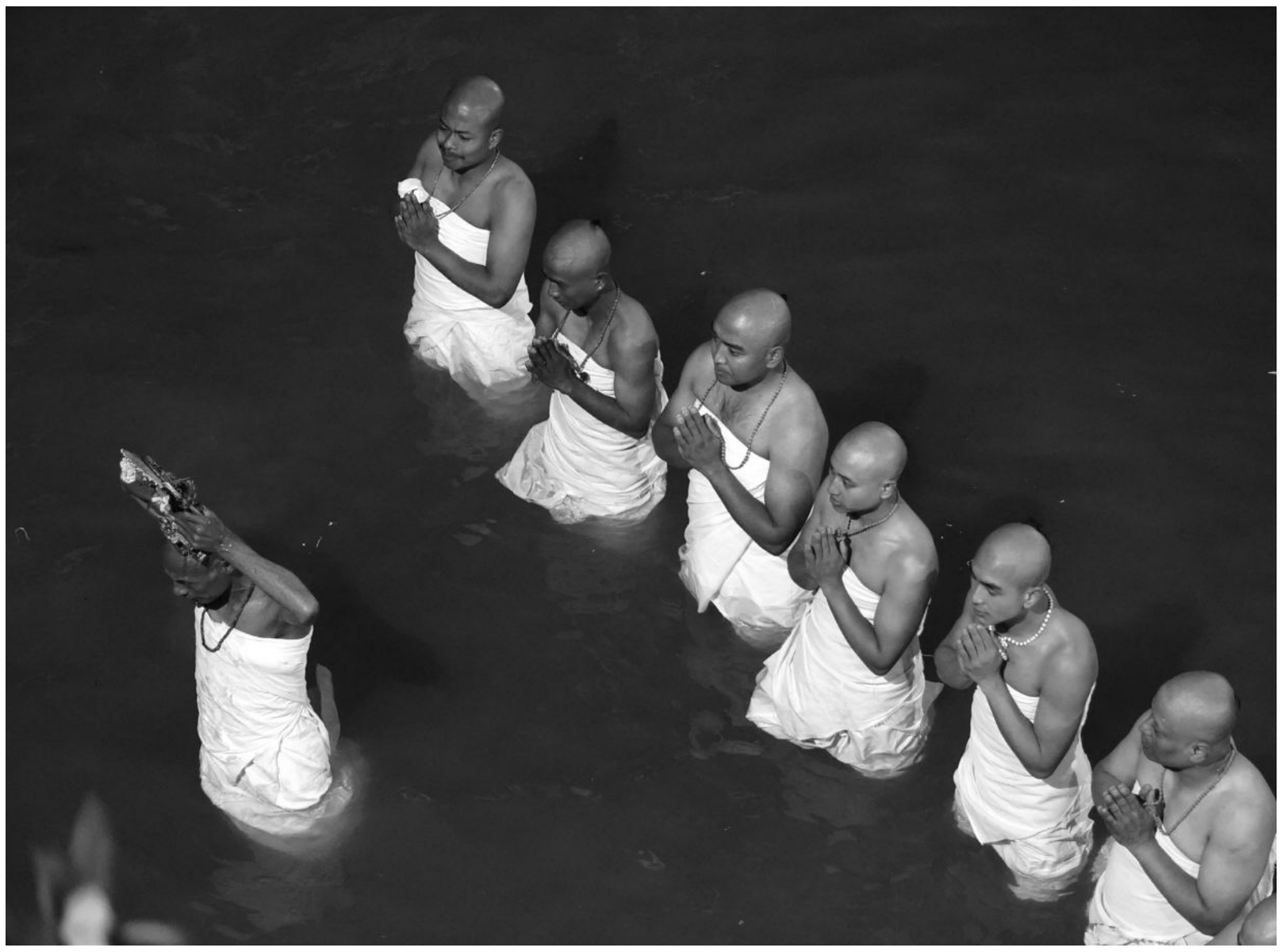


PHOTO: SAGAR BASNET/TRN

Devotees taking a holy bath in Shalinadi of Sankhu, Kathmandu on the occasion of a month long fasting of Swasthani Brata that began on Thursday.

AUSTRALIAN ENVOY CALLS ON PRESIDENT

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 25

Ambassador of Australia to Nepal, Felicity Jane Volk, paid a courtesy call on the President of Nepal, Ramchandra Paudel on Thursday. During the meeting, bilateral relations between Nepal and Australia, mutual interests and concerns were discussed, informed Spokesperson of the Office of the President, Shailaja Regmi Bhattarai in a statement.

On the occasion, President Paudel said that he was confident that Australia's support for the social and economic development of a land-locked and underdeveloped country like Nepal will increase in the future.

UN UNDER SECRETARY GENERAL MEETS SPEAKER GHIMIRE

RSS
Kathmandu, Jan. 25

The United Nations Under Secretary-General and the High Representative for Disarmament Affairs, Ms Izumi Nakamitsu, called on Speaker of the House of Representatives, Devraj Ghimire on Thursday.

During the meeting, they held discussions on the United Nations' and Nepal's efforts towards disarmament, the action plan on control of small and light weapons, and endorsement of the international treaty, among other topics.

French President Macron arrives in India

He will be chief guest at National Day celebrations

AP
New Delhi, Jan. 25

The French president arrived in India on Thursday, where he is expected to meet with Prime Minister Narendra Modi and will be the chief guest at the country's national day celebrations.

Emmanuel Macron began his visit with some sightseeing in the western city of Jaipur, a popular tourist destination, where he visited a 17th-century fort and an 18th-century observatory.

Macron will hold talks with Prime Minister Narendra Modi later Thursday in Jaipur before flying to New Delhi. The two leaders are expected to discuss major global challenges in economic, defense, space and cyber security, as well as France's role in the Indo-Pacific region.

France is looking to strengthen cooperation with India in areas ranging from climate to military sales, despite frictions over the two countries' attitudes to Russia's war on Ukraine.

They are expected to continue discussions on India's plans to purchase 26 French Rafale fighter aircraft for its navy, approved by India's Defense Acquisition Council last year. The council also approved a plan to purchase three Scorpene submarines, jointly developed by France and Spain.

France already has delivered 36 Rafale fighter aircraft ordered by the Indian Air Force.

France has reiterated its commitment to a defense relationship with India, including sharing technology. The two countries are working on co-development and co-production defense projects, the Indian External Affairs Ministry said.



PHOTO: AP

Indian Foreign Minister S. Jaishankar, right, welcoming French President Emmanuel Macron, left upon his arrival in Jaipur, Rajasthan, India on Thursday.

"Macron is committed to the pursuit of a closer dialogue with India, a key player on the international scene from a demographic point of view, as well as economic, scientific and diplomatic," his office said in a statement.

France is looking to strengthen cooperation with India in areas ranging from climate to military sales, despite frictions over the two countries' attitudes to Russia's war on Ukraine.

Three ministers are traveling with the President: Sébastien Lecornu, Minister of the Armed Forces; Stéphane Sejourne, Minister for Europe and Foreign Affairs; and Rachida Dati, Minister of Culture.

On Friday, Macron will be the guest of honor at India's Republic Day parade in New Delhi celebrating the anniversary of the adoption of the country's constitution in 1950, nearly three years after it won independence from British colonial rule.

Modi was a guest of honor at Bastille Day parade in Paris in July last year, where Macron called India a key player "in our future."

Macron visited India in November for the Group of 20 summit of industrialized and developing nations.

Indian exports to France totaled $3.06 billion and imports from France $2.36 billion in the past year, according to India's External Affairs Ministry.

6.5 M school textbooks remain to be printed for next session

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 25

School students appear set to receive their textbooks before their admission into the next academic session. The Prime Minister's Secretariat provided the information after conducting a surprise inspection of the Janak Education Materials Centre (JEMC) on Thursday.

Meeting with the Secretariat team, which comprised the Prime Minister's Public Relations expert Buddhi GC, Personal Joint Secretary Gokarna Bhatta, Joint Secretary Sangita Ojha and others, JEMC ManagingDirector Anil Kumar Jha informed that they had finished purchasing the required paper and were working throughout the day. "We have implemented a two-shift system to work 24 hours a day, seven days a week," he said. "As we print here, we are also simultaneously transporting the printed books to various depots."

Recounting how they had succeeded in delivering the books in time last year despite receiving the paper only after January, Jha said that they would deliver the books this year too as they had received the paper in time.

Bhatta said that the Secretariat had presented the Centre suggestions for improvement and had felt the need to consult with the Ministry of Education to solve policy issues. "Though the work is satisfactory, the quality of printing needs to be improved," he said.

GC instructed JEMC to keep the printed books safe, not waste paper and maintain quality in publication.

The government had earlier decided to entrust the private sector with publishing textbooks for grades 1 to 4 and give JEMC the responsibility of publishing books for grades 5 to 12. This is believed to have allowed Janak to accelerate publication.

Of the total 17 million textbooks that JEMC needed to print for the next academic session, only 6.5 million remain to be printed, the Centre informed. According to Janak's management, the Centre is printing 70,000 to 80,000 books per day.

Corruption case filed in purchase of sanitary pads

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 25

The Commission for the Investigation of Abuse of Authority (CIAA) filed two corruption cases against 13 individuals at the Special Court, Kathmandu on Wednesday.

The CIAA filed a case against Rupani Rural Municipality's then chief administrative officer Arbind Kumar Chaudhary, account officer Shyam Sundar Yadav, secondary level teacher Shyam Prasad Yadav, non-gazetted first class officer Sujan Dahal and Shree Laxmi Traders and Suppliers Rajbiraj proprietor Lalita Kumari Sah.

According to the CIAA, these five defendants manipulated the price of sanitary pads, doubling the market price while purchasing pads for community schools in the Fiscal Year 2020/023. At the time, the Nepal Government had allocated a budget for the free distribution of sanitary pads under Conditional Grants.

They caused a loss of Rs. 874,003 to the rural municipality by making payments of Rs. 1,758,925 to proprietor Sah though the original cost was only Rs. 911,925.

The CIAA demanded all defendants be punished in accordance with Article 8 of the Prevention of Corruption Act-2002 and fined Rs. 874,003.

Similarly, the CIAA filed a case against Madkechula Rural Municipality's then executive chief administrative officer Singh Raj Dangi, Engineer Devraj Rawat and Sub-engineer Deep Narayan Yadav for financial irregularities during the construction of a road from Mahadev Khola to Ghamta Khola of Ward No. 8 in the Fiscal Year 2019/020.

In the same case, the CIAA has also presented Ward No. 8 chair Dhan Bahadur Rokaya, former working committee member Ram Kumar Nepali, ward technician Ishara Budha and Consumer Committee of Road Construction from Ghumcho Khola to Mahadev chairman Road Man Bahadur Rokaya and treasurer Nirmal Rokaya as defendants.

They made payments of Rs. 1,097,852 to the consumer committee for the construction of the road despite the work being incomplete.

The CIAA demanded a fine of Rs. 1,097,852 and punishment in accordance with Article 8 and19 of the Prevention of Corruption Act-2002 to the defendants.

Govt urged to take action on unlawful children homes

RSS
Kathmandu, Jan. 25

The National Women Commission (NWC) has drawn the attention of the government to take action against the guilty after carrying out investigation on illegally operated children homes.

Issuing a press release on Thursday, the NWC laid emphasis on the need of operating children homes in a systematic manner because it is unsafe for the children to take shelter at such facilities. Minimum standards must be met by the children homes, it added.

The NWC had carried out monitoring of Gokarneshwor municipality-based Lab Prasad Sudhar Sangh, a children home, on November 21, 2023, based on the information that it was running illegally and the children were at unsafe condition. It then recommended the bodies concerned to immediately rescue the children from there.

After the monitoring, the report prepared by the Commission mentioned that the children home had involved the children physical, sexual and criminal activities, which it argued, was sheer violation of children's rights.

PM's earnest...

Noting how they had defended the constitution and laws against attacks in the past, he asked the ex-judges to maintain the same level of vigilance in the future too. He also said that the people in the responsible positions should not make decisions based on mob opinion or statements expressed on social media.

Meanwhile, the former judges suggested the Prime Minister to work to strengthen the current system as the executive head of the nation.

Congress with...

The call extends to party members at various levels, well-wishers, and individuals associated with fraternal and benevolent organizations. This collaborative effort aims to make the campaign impactful and beneficial at the community level, reinforcing the party's commitment to incorporating citizens' input into its policy-making processes.

The Nepali Congress encourages widespread participation, highlighting the importance of collective efforts in making the Community Congress campaign a meaningful and constructive endeavour for all involved, read the statement.

Informal economy in...

Another highly informal area of the national economy is agriculture, forestry and fishing which is 96.48 per cent. However, agricultural activities have been more formalised in recent years.

Other highly informal sectors are accommodation and food service 50.42 per cent, and arts and entertainment 33.69 per cent.

The study suggested that given the extent of the informal economy shown in the study, further research is needed to understand the nature, type and coverage of the informal economy in Nepal.

A survey-based study is needed to further diagnose the identified areas where such informal transactions are prevalent.

"Given that Nepal shares a 1770-kilometer open border with India and that the significant cross-border trades are informal, it may also be helpful to understand how such informal transactions are carried out by businesses operating in the bordering areas," suggested the study.

This may involve interviewing stakeholders from the local levels in bordering areas (such as small businesses, and security and customs officials, local community) to those at the national level (such as big traders and manufacturers, and security and customs officials).

Tribeni Dham gaining...

Apart from that, as per his observation, fewer people are opting for boat rides nowadays, he concluded.

Chiran Gurung, who has been operating a boat on the river to sustain his household expenses, also expresses concern about the recent lack of income.

"So far, this boat has been the sole source of household expenses. If I were to pursue something else, I lack the necessary skills," he said. The income from this boat is vital for covering the family expenses, especially children's education, he added.

Jhapendrashwar Bhusal, director of the Gajendra Moksha Divya Dham Development Committee, mentioned that efforts are being made to develop Triveni Dham as a tourist destination within the country, not only during Maghe Aausi Mela but also at other times when boat rides could be operated.

Nabil launches entrepreneurship loan targeting returning migrants

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 25

Nabil Bank has launched a special entrepreneurship loan product to support the returnee Nepali migrant workers in establishing and running business in the area they are proficient.

Minister for Labour, Employment and Social Security, Sharat Singh Bhandari, and Chairman of the bank, Upendra Prasad Poudyal jointly launched the product - Nabil Skilled Migrant Entrepreneurship Loan - at a programme organised in Kathmandu on Thursday.

The loan is designed for income-generating activities or enterprise that offers flexible features such as loan limit up to Rs. 100 million for tenure of up to 10 years.

The bank said that it provides attractive interest rate for the product which is 1.50 per cent over base rate. In addition to that, there will be an efficient approval process of loan from minimum of 3 to 5 days to ease and facilitate returnee migrants.

"The bank believes that the loan scheme plays vital role in addressing the unique financial needs of returning immigrants, promoting entrepreneurship through their acquired knowledge and expertise. By actively participating in national development efforts, Nabil Bank aims to create an environment that nurtures returning migrants in pursuing their business goals and contributing to the country's economic growth," said the bank.

Speaking on the occasion, Minister Bhandari said that foreign employment has become highly competitive but Nepali workers are less competitive in skill, technology and language.

He highlighted the government's initiative to curb brain drain and encouraged youths to return home and be part of positive change. He further emphasized that the government is working closely with the private sector to motivate more Nepali settled abroad to return home and start businesses.

Stating that Nabil Bank's initiative in introducing such programme is praiseworthy, he said, "Financial support is the key support in establishing business and the commitment that Nabil Bank is making to providing easy, accessible and subsidized loan to returnee migrants will definitely help on the government's drive to returning youths to home country."

According to Minister Bhandari, returnees are more skilled and responsible in their economic and social dealings, and the country needed a system to certify their skill and opportunities to further enhancement of skills.

Kewal Prasad Bhandari, Secretary of the Ministry of Labour, Employment and Social Security (MoLESS), said that various programmes are being implemented with the support from the destination countries like Japan and Korea to provide support to the returnee migrant.

"Most of the returnees need small financial support, our surveys have shown. So, they should be supported in the production, promotion and marketing their products," he said.

CELEBRATING 75TH REPUBLIC DAY OF INDIA

AMBASSADOR'S MESSAGE



As India celebrates its 75th Republic Day, I extend warm greetings to my fellow Indians and friends of India in Nepal. on this day in 1950, India's constitution came into effect, embodying the hopes and aspirations of a nation. Today, as we celebrate this milestone, we also reaffirm our resolve to make India a developed nation by 2047 as envisioned by our Hon'ble Prime Minister.

India's progress on its journey to become a developed nation in this *'Amrit Kaal'* is also manifested in a more dynamic Neighbourhood First policy with the guiding philosophy of *Sabka Saath, Sabka Vikas, Sabka Vishwas, Sabka Prayas*. This is underlined in our relationship with Nepal where the millennia old civilizational links are being transformed into a modern partnership for mutual benefit.

The visit of the Right Hon'ble Mr. Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda', Prime Minister of Nepal to India in May-June 2023, was a milestone in this regard. Prime Minister Prachanda and Prime Minister of India Shri Narendra Modi took several decisions to provide impetus to our ties and to make our partnership 'SuperHIT'. These decisions included announcements to construct new Integrated Check Posts (ICP), agreement on the Revised Transit Treaty that provides for access to India's inland waterways for Nepal's transit cargo, cross border freight rail operations, building of new motorable bridges at Shirsha and Jhulaghat to connect Nepal's far-west to India and facilitation of digital payments for seamless financial connectivity.

Both countries have made significant strides towards enhancing energy connectivity. The inauguration of three new 132 kV cross-border transmission lines, groundbreaking of the Indian portion of 400 kV Gorakhpur-New Butwal transmission line, MoU between National Thermal Power Corporation (NTPC) and Nepal Electricity Authority (NEA) for cooperation in renewables, foundation stone laying of Phase-II of the Motihari-Amlekhgunj Pipeline and an MoU for new oil pipelines between Amlekhgunj-Chitwan and Siliguri-Jhapa will help strengthen our cooperation across the entire spectrum of energy.

The decision to conclude a Long Term Agreement on Power Trade by the two Prime Ministers has added a new chapter. This Agreement, which was signed earlier this month, strives to increase the quantum of export of power from Nepal to India to 10,000 MW within a timeframe of ten years. Nepal has in 2023 exported hydro-power worth NPR 15 billion to India. This export showcases the immense potential of this mutually beneficial cooperation. The two countries are also in the process of enhancing regional trade in power with Bangladesh.

As a trusted friend and partner, India also remains the First Responder in the time of crises. Following the unfortunate earthquake in Jajarkot, India provided immediate relief supplies. During recent visit of the External Affairs Minister of India Dr. S Jaishankar to Nepal, fifth tranche of relief material was handed over to Nepal, including prefabricated houses and other essential supplies. India has also announced financial assistance of NPR 1000 crore to support Nepal's reconstruction efforts.

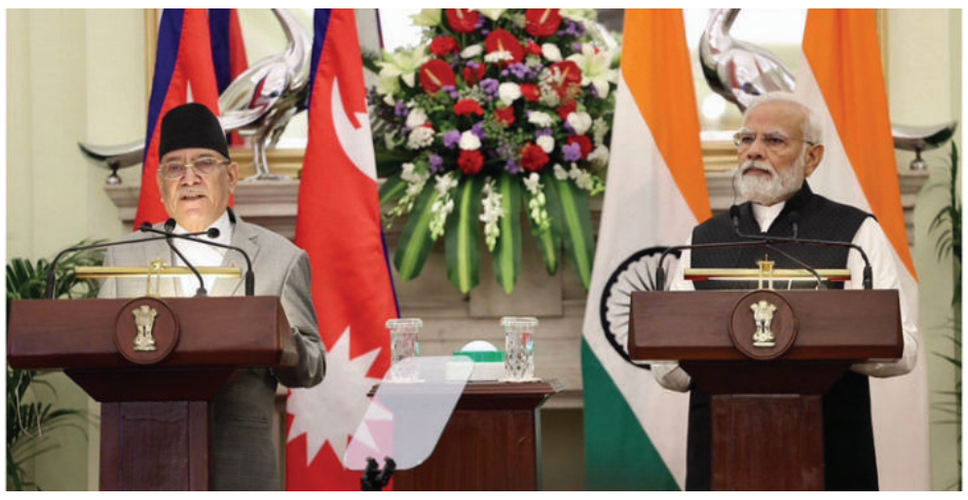
Last year also saw our partnership evolve and expand to new frontiers. We have concluded an agreement for launch of a satellite developed by students of Nepal Academy of Science & Technology. Further, India's capabilities in areas such as space technology, showcased by Chandrayaan-3 Mission, also open up new avenues for cooperation in the future. Cricket has emerged as an exciting area of cooperation that will further strengthen our people-to-people ties, which have been a cornerstone of our age-old relationship. Digital Public Infrastructure and PM GatiShakti for Multimodal Connectivity are other areas where India's experience can be of use to Nepal as it proceeds on its developmental journey.

India and Nepal are also working together in global arena too. Nepal's constructive participation under Finance Track of the G20 Summit last year which was chaired by India as well as in the Voice of Global South Summits hosted by India reflect this. India's successful G20 Presidency, themed 'One Earth, One Family, One Future', underlined the need for promoting strong as well as sustainable, balanced, and inclusive growth and highlighted the unique needs and aspirations of developing nations. It provides new opportunities for India and Nepal to further enhance coordination.

I am confident that in 2024 both countries will continue to take steps to take our multifaceted partnership to greater heights for the prosperity of our peoples.

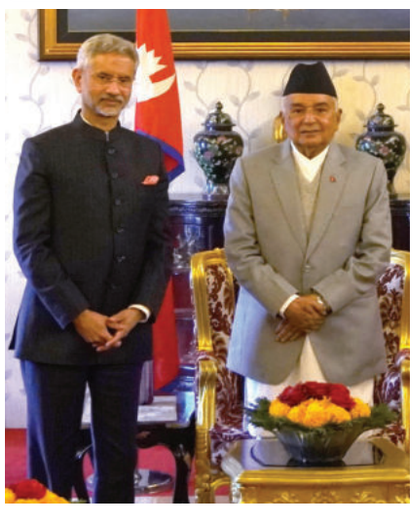
(Naveen Srivastava)

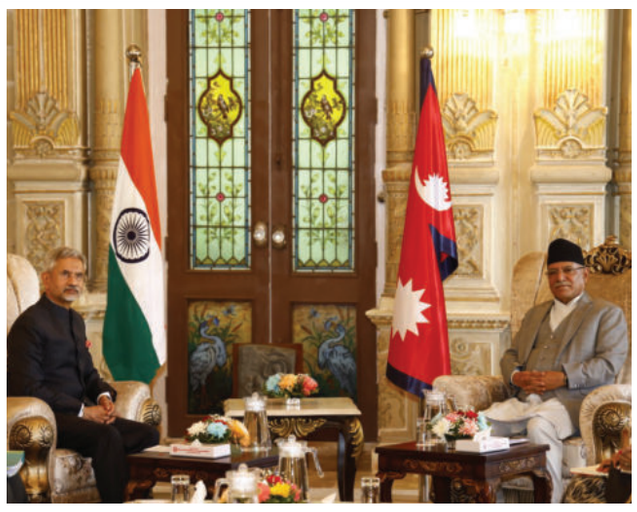
STRENGTHENING INDIA-NEPAL RELATIONSHIP



o The visit of Rt. Hon'ble Prime Minister of Nepal, Mr. Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' to India in May-June 2023 witnessed historic decisions following his discussions with Hon'ble Prime Minister of India Shri Narendra Modi, including related to long-term power trade, development of hydropower projects, new petroleum pipelines, and cross-border payments.

VISIT OF EXTERNAL AFFAIRS MINISTER







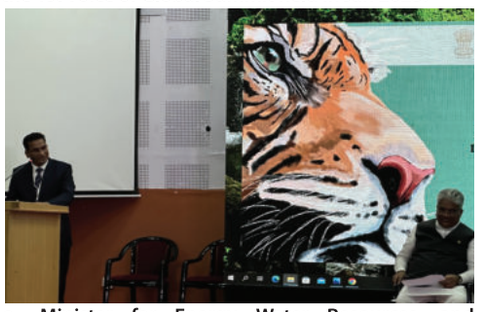
o External Affairs Minister of India, Dr. S Jaishankar paid an official visit to Nepal from 4-5 Jan 2024 for the 7th meeting of the India-Nepal Joint Commission. The meeting of the Commission reviewed the entire spectrum of bilateral cooperation between India and Nepal. During his visit, agreements were signed for Long Term Power Trade; Launch Service for Munal Satellite developed by Nepal Academy of Science & Technology; Cooperation in Renewable Energy Development between NTPC Limited and Nepal Electricity Authority; and Implementation of High Impact Community Development Projects (HICDPs) in Nepal. EAM Dr. Jaishankar and Foreign Minister of Nepal, Mr. N.P. Saud jointly inaugurated three 132 kV cross-border transmission lines between India and Nepal: the second circuit of Raxaul-Parwanipur line; the second circuit of Kataiya-Kusaha line; and the New Nautanwa-Mainhiya lines. The two Ministers also inaugurated 59 post-earthquake reconstruction projects in education, health and culture sectors, including the new building of Tribhuvan University Central Library building, built with Government of India's grant assistance. During his visit, EAM Dr. S Jaishankar called on Rt. Hon'ble President of Nepal, Mr. Ram Chandra Paudel and Rt. Hon'ble Prime Minister of Nepal, Mr. Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda'.



o Strengthening South-South Cooperation: Rt. Hon'ble Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' participated in the 2nd Voice of Global Summit in November 2023. Nepal also participated in the 1st Voice of Global Summit held in Jan 2023.



o Finance Minister of Nepal participated in the 10th Vibrant Gujarat Global Summit held from 10-12 Jan 2024. Nepal was also a Partner Country along with Japan, Finland, Germany, UAE, etc. for the Summit.



o Minister for Energy, Water Resources, and Irrigation, Mr. Shakti Bahadur Basnet attended the launch of the International Big Cat Alliance for conservation of seven big cats namely tiger, lion, leopard, snow leopard, cheetah, jaguar and puma in Mysuru on 9 April 2023.



o Former Deputy Prime Minister & Finance Minister, Mr. Bishnu Prasad Paudel attended the First G20 Finance Ministers and Central Bank Governors (FMCBG) meeting at Bengaluru, Karnataka from 24-25 Feb 2023. The meeting was held during G20 Presidency of India.

NEIGHBOURHOOD FIRST: INDIA'S RELIEF EFFORTS



o India has been the first responder to Nepal in times of crisis, be it the 2015 earthquake in Nepal, COVID-19 pandemic or the recent earthquake in Jajarkot and West Rukum districts. Following the Jajarkot Earthquake, India responded with immediate relief supplies and provided 5 tranches of relief materials, including tents, tarpaulin sheets, blankets, and sleeping bags along with essential medicines and medical equipment. India has also announced financial assistance NPR 1000 crore to support Nepal's reconstruction efforts.







INDIA'S G20 PRESIDENCY "ONE EARTH . ONE FAMILY . ONE FUTURE"





DEVELOPMENT PARTNERSHIP



o The year 2023 marked the 20-year milestone of the High Impact Community Development Projects (HICDP), encompassing over 550 projects in priority sectors of Government of Nepal, with a total grant assistance of over NPR 12 billion.



o Motihari-Amlekhgunj Pipeline (Phase-II) along with additional new pipelines at Amlekhgunj-Chitwan and Siliguri–Jhapa and construction of greenfield terminals at Chitwan and Jhapa will strengthen energy connectivity.



o Under the post-earthquake 2015 reconstruction, more than 100 reconstruction projects in Health, Education, and Cultural sectors have been inaugurated since the beginning of 2023, including Tribhuvan University Central Library.

SECTORAL COOPERATION



o A delegation from Nepal visited India from 13-19 Oct 2023 to see various aspects of implementation of PM Gati Shakti - National Master Plan for Multi-modal Connectivity.



o 11th meeting of the Joint Steering Committee on Power Sector Cooperation was held in Chitwan on 5 January 2024. The meeting comprehensively reviewed the bilateral power sector cooperation.





974 Ambulances Gifted 234 School Buses Gifted

DEFENCE COOPERATION



Surya Kiran: 17th iteration of the India-Nepal Joint Military Exercise 'Surya Kiran, was conducted in India in Dec 2023 where an Infantry Battalion from each country trained together.



o Fifteenth Meeting of the India-Nepal Bilateral Consultative Group on Security Issues was held at Pokhara in Nepal in Oct 2023. The discussions covered issues relating to mutual security & defence cooperation.

EDUCATION & TRAINING COOPERATION



o Around 1500 scholarships are provided every year by India to Nepali nationals for undergoing various courses in India as well in Nepal.

For Study In Nepal

500 Under the Mahatma Gandhi Scholarship Scheme (MGSS) for studying in XI & XII.

200 Under Golden Jubilee Scholarship Scheme (GJSS) for various Undergraduate courses.

For Study India

700 For various Undergraduate, Postgraduate and PhD courses.

33 For studying in Army Public Schools in India



Under Indian Technical and Economic Cooperation (ITEC), in calendar year 2023, 500 professionals from Nepal were trained in 91 courses in 47 prominent institutes of India such as IIT Roorkee, IIM Kozhikode, St. Stephen College of University of Delhi etc.

CULTURAL CONNECT



India-Nepal Cultural Festival was organized in Lumbini, the birthplace of Lord Buddha, in Dec 2023 to showcase the rich cultural heritage and traditions of India and Nepal, with a focus on Buddhism.



Dashain Mahotsav was held on 14 Oct 2023 to celebrate the shared cultural heritage of India and Nepal. The event witnessed performances by an emerging Nepali band Sonagi Blues and students of the Swami Vivekananda Cultural Centre.



Jaiswal leads India's reply against England

AFP
Hyderabad, Jan. 25

Opener Yashasvi Jaiswal led India's charging reply to England's 246, which had been driven by captain Ben Stokes' half-century on an all-attacking opening day of the first Test on Thursday.

The hosts were 119-1 at stumps in Hyderabad and trailing England by 127 runs, with skipper Rohit Sharma (24) the sole wicket. Jaiswal, on 76 off 70 balls, and Shubman Gill, on 14, were batting at close of play.

Left-hander Jaiswal reached his fifty in 47 balls with a boundary off debutant Tom Hartley, whose bruising introduction to Test cricket saw him leak 63 runs from nine overs.

Stokes top-scored with 70 after the visitors opted to bat first, sticking to their ultra-attacking "Bazball" strategy to counter India's renowned home-turf spin prowess. England had lost regular wickets until Stokes took charge and lifted the total, smashing six fours and three sixes.

He also put together key lower-order stands with Hartley (23) and Mark Wood (11) before he was finally bowled by paceman Jasprit Bumrah after tea in the final wicket of the innings.

England had started the day briskly, with Ben Duckett (35) and Zak Crawley (20) putting on an opening stand of 55, with regular boundaries off Bumrah and Mohammed Siraj.

Da Silva, Hodge lead WIndies

Joshua Da Silva and Kavem Hodge rallied West Indies to 266-8 against Australia with resolute half-centuries on day one of the day-night test at the Gabba on Thursday.

Da Silva (79) and Hodge (71) shared a 149-run stand in almost two sessions in a rare frustrating day for the Australians in a home season that's seen them whitewash Pakistan 3-0 and win the first test against the West Indies at Adelaide by 10 wickets.

Off-spinning allrounder Kevin Sinclair, who made his test debut in place of Gudakesh Motie, was unbeaten on 16 while Alzarri Joseph counterpunched with seven boundaries among 32 runs before he edged Josh Hazlewood in the slips in the last over.

Nathan Lyon broke up Da Silva and Hodge two overs before the second new ball became available. Lyon trapped Da Silva lbw on the back foot while bowling round the wicket. The batter went for an unsuccessful referral.

The second pink ball netted Hodge and Joseph.

Hodge was caught at second slip off Mitchell Starc, who took 4-68.

Da Silva's patient 157-ball knock included seven boundaries. He braved a brief spell of short balls from the Australian quicks in the second session during which captain Pat Cummins used seven bowlers without any success.

Hodge, in his second test, pulled Starc for six over fine leg after dinner and hit eight boundaries in his 194-ball innings, playing some impressive drives to overpitched deliveries on the off side.

Madhes' batters shine against Gandaki

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 25

After scoring a century on Thursday, Madhes Province's wicketkeeper-batsman Anil Kumar Sah is now the current highest scorer in the ongoing PM Cup Men's National Cricket Tournament with 370 runs in eight matches. Sah scored two half-centuries in earlier matches.

Opening the inning with Captain Hari Shankar Sah, Anil stayed in the crease until the 38th over. He fell as the fourth wicket after scoring 127 off 125 deliveries with six maximums and 11 fours.

Hari departed in the first ball of the second over at 2 runs off 6 balls.

Anil was supported by two other highest scorers in the league – Pawan Sarraf and Mayan Yadav. Sarraf added 40 off 38 and Yadav contributed with 27 off 44. Sarraf and Yadav are the third and fourth-highest scorers in the tournament with 303 and 265 runs respectively.

Madhes was able to give a massive target of 336 runs to Gandaki at the TU International Cricket Ground, Kirtipur, on Day 13.

Arniko Yadav was the match's second-highest scorer with 63 off 34. Rupesh Singh and Abhishek Tiwari added 32 and 27 runs respectively.

Madhes has now been involved in all three matches of the edition where a target of over 300 runs has been posted. While Madhes was on the receiving end against Tribhuwan Army Club on January 15, it gave a target of 320 to Sudur Pashchim on January 22.

In the chase, seven batsmen of Gandaki scored in double figures, but insufficiently. Gandaki fell short of 145 runs as it got bowled out in the 40th over at 190. Opener Ishwar Chhetri and Kamal Pariyar, who came in at 8, scored 27 runs each for the team.

Ranjit Kumar fell one wicket short for a fifer, captain Sah bagged three, Pradip Paswan claimed two and Rajesh Yadav took the remaining one for Madhes.

Bagmati bags fifth win

Though Anil is at the top of the highest scorers' list, he has only two runs more than Bagmati's opener Ashutosh Ghiraiya. Scoring his second half-century of the edition against Sudur Pashchim at Mulpani on Thursday, Ghiraiya, who hit a century against Koshi, now has 368 runs in eight matches.

Alongside Ghiraiya, captain Rit Gautam and Ashok Poudel added 44 and 31 runs respectively as the team posted a target of 248 against Sudur Pashchim in the loss of nine wickets. Narayan Joshi and Sher Malla took three wickets each against Bagmati.

However, as only three batsmen crossed the double-figure mark in the chase, Sudur Paschim was bundled out in the 31st over at 150 runs. Naren Bhatta and Kiran Thagunna added 41 runs each followed by 21 runs from the bat of opener Khadak Bohora.

With Rijan Dhakal, Krijan Gurung and Sonu Devkota claiming one wicket each, Surya Tamang and Bipin Acharya bagged three each for Bagmati.

Surya Tamang is the highest wicket-taker in the tournament with 24 wickets in eight matches. He is followed by Sudur Pashchim's Sher Malla with 21 wickets in six matches.

APF triumphs

Nevertheless, in the third match of the day, Nepal Armed Police Force (APF) Club defeated Lumbini Province in Siddharthanagar Cricket Ground, Rupandehi, by seven wickets.

Electing to bat first, Lumbini was bundled out at a score of 133 in 41 overs. Birat Bhandari was the first wicket to fall for Lumbini in the 14th over after scoring 23 off 51 deliveries. Meanwhile, Mrinal Gurung, another opener, stayed until the 32nd over facing 88 balls to add 34 runs to the board.

Dilsad Ali, who came in at seven, was the highest scorer for Lumbini with 39 off 42, and he stayed not out.

Ramesh Kurmi claimed a fifer for APF followed by three wickets by Bhuvan Karki. Captain Rohit Paudel and Mousom Dhakal also bagged one each.

Playing his sixth match of the season, Paudel scored his fourth half-century on Thursday. APF lost its two openers by the sixth over when the team was at 28 runs. Puran BK and Paudel then partnered to take the team to 127 runs by the 23rd over as Paudel departed at 52 off 48.

BK (33 off 57) stayed not out with Amar Routela (8 off 2) to ensure the third win for APF in six matches and keep the hopes for the top 4 alive. Mohammad Hussain, Krishna Karki and Iklakh Ahmed bagged one wicket each.



PHOTO CREDIT: CAN
Anil Shah of Madhes Province raises his bat after completing a hundred runs against Gandaki Province at PM Cup National Men's One Day Cricket Championship at TU Cricket Ground, Kirtipur, Thursday.

SNIPPETS

Sukra maintains lead

Dharan (TRN): Local pro Sukra Bahadur Rai maintained a one-stroke lead over Niraj Tamang after the second round of the Surya Nepal Eastern Open at the par-70 Dharan Golf Club on Thursday. Nepal No. 1 pro and defending champion Sukra played 1-over 71 on the second day for a 36-hole total of 2-under 138. He was able to keep the one-stroke lead after fellow Dharan pro Niraj also played 1-over 71 for a total score of 1-under 139. Former top pro Bhuvan Nagarkoti climbed to third at 2-over 142 despite playing 2-over 72 in the second round. He is tied with amateur section leader Yubraj Bhujel. Three pros, Rabi Khadka, Rajen Rai and Bhuwan Kumar Rokka carded 1-under 69 each and they are tied for fourth at 4-over 144. In the amateur section, Bhujel is at the top with a score of 2-over 142.

NSC mulls over National Para Games

Kathmandu (TRN): The National Sports Council is gearing up to organise a national-level Para games. Council's member-secretary Tanka Lal Ghising met with concerned stakeholders on Wednesday and discussed the issue. Globally, after the completion of the Olympics and Asian Games, a similar level of Para games is organised within a few weeks. The council has discussed organising Para Games in Nepal for the first time after the completion of the National Games. In the meeting participated by Min Kumar Sharma, chief of sports tournament and planning division in the council, and sports development division's Saroj Kumar Pokharel among other stakeholders from different associations, Ghising directed the drafting of a preliminary gameplan for the Para games based on the number of players available to compete. He also assured of making Para games an integral part of the council and conducting them timely and directed concerned bodies to construct disabled-friendly sports infrastructure.

Jawalakhel stuns Machhindra

Kathmandu (TRN): Jawalakhel Youth Club won its match against Machhindra FC in the 23rd Aaha! Rara Pokhara Gold Cup at Pokhara Rangasala on Thursday. Hishub Thapaliya scored the only goal of the match to knock Machhindra out of the tournament. Both the teams had chances to score more goals. Led by goalie Bishal Shrestha as the captain, Machhindra, with Bimal Gharti Magar as a striker, could not capitalise on several chances to either equalise or win the match. Jawalakhel will now play against Manang Marshyangdi Club in the quarter-finals on January 29. Nepal Police Club and APF Football Club are competing in a departmental derby on Friday for a place in the quarter-finals against Church Boys United FC.

Sabalenka, Zheng march into Australian Open final

AP
Melbourne, Jan. 25

Defending champion Aryna Sabalenka avenged a U.S. Open final loss to Coco Gauff and will meet first-time finalist Zheng Qinwen at the Australian Open on Saturday.

Sabalenka attacked Gauff's serve with her powerful returns and unloaded 33 winners in the 7-6 (2), 6-4 semifinal victory on Thursday night that extended her winning streak to 13 matches at Melbourne Park.

No. 12-seeded Zheng defeated Ukrainian qualifier Dayana Yastremska 6-4, 6-4 in the second semifinal in Rod Laver Arena.

Zheng lost in the U.S. Open quarterfinals to Sabalenka last year in her best previous run at a major. She's into the final a decade after Chinese star Li Na won the Australian title.

"It feels unbelievable. I'm super excited to have such a great performance today and arrive in the final," Zheng said.

Sabalenka was back in the semis for the fifth straight major, a run that started here in Australia last year in her Grand Slam breakthrough. She's the first since reach consecutive finals here since Williams did in 2015, '16 and '17.

After the match, Sabalenka acknowledged tennis greats in the crowd including Billie Jean King and Evonne Goolagong Cawley, who was celebrating the 50th anniversary of her first Australian Open title.

"I couldn't dream (of) playing in front of you," Sabalenka said. "Thank you for everything you've done for our sport. It's a privilege to play in front of you."

In doubles, 43-year-old Rohan Bopanna and Matthew Ebden advanced to their second consecutive Grand Slam men's final by beating Zhang Zhizhen and Tomas Machac 6-3, 3-6, 7-6 (7).



CUMMINS, BRUNT SCOOP TOP HONOURS AT ICC AWARDS

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 25

The International Cricket Council (ICC) on Thursday revealed that Australia captain Pat Cummins has won the Sir Garfield Sobers Trophy for ICC Men's Cricketer of the Year and England all-rounder Nat Sciver-Brunt has won her second successive Rachael Heyhoe Flint Trophy for ICC Women's Cricketer of the Year.

Both players were recognised as the outstanding cricketers across all formats of international cricket in 2023, scooping the top honours at ICC Awards following four days of announcements on ICC official channels, where Teams of the Year and individual award winners in 13 categories had been unveiled since Monday.

Winners in the ICC Awards were determined from votes cast by an independent panel of prominent media representatives - the ICC Voting Academy - and hundreds of thousands of global cricket fans, who had been voting for their top performers in 2023 since early January.

Among the other international stars to celebrate individual accolades in the ICC Awards 2023 through Thursday's announcements were Australia batter Usman Khawaja (ICC Men's Test Cricketer of the Year), India batter Virat Kohli (ICC Men's ODI Cricketer of the Year), Sri Lanka captain and all-rounder Chamari Athapaththu (ICC Women's ODI Cricketer of the Year), Richard Illingworth (ICC Umpire of the Year) and players from Zimbabwe, who won the ICC Spirit of Cricket Award.

Madrid take top spot in football's 'Money League'

AFP
London, Jan. 25

Real Madrid have climbed to the top of football's 'Money League' as the Spanish side surpassed Manchester City to become the highest revenue-generating club in 2022-23.

For the first time since 2017-18, Real are in pole positon in Deloitte's financial rankings with a reported record revenue of 831 million euros ($905 million), an increase of 118 million euros over the previous year.

Although they failed to win La Liga last season -- finishing 10 points behind champions Barcelona -- and lost in the Champions League semi-finals to Manchester City, Real's growth is largely attributable to strong retail performance, higher stadium attendance and recovery of sponsorship income following the easing of Covid-19 restrictions.

Manchester City, who won the Premier League, Champions League and FA Cup last season, fall to second place in the 2024 rankings.

The club reported its highest ever revenue for a season, 826 million euros, and bolstered both broadcast and commercial revenues by 50 million euros and 26 million euros respectively.

French champions Paris Saint-Germain broke into the top three for the first time, with revenues of 802 million euros.

Barcelona are in fourth position as their 800 million euros revenue lifted them from seventh place, with club record licensing and merchandising revenues and fans returning to stadiums.

Commercial revenue represented the largest income stream for 'Money League' clubs for the first time since the 2015-16 season, excluding the Covid-19 impacted 2019-20 season.

Seventeen of the top 20 clubs reported a year-on-year increase in commercial revenue, with growth largely attributable to improved retail sales, revenue from non-matchday events and recovery of sponsorship income which had been impacted by the pandemic.

WEATHER

Friday

Sunrise at 6:54 am, Sunset at 5:39 pm

Forecast for Nepal (Friday)

Partly to generally cloudy in the hilly areas and Partly cloudy to mainly fair in rest of the country. Chances of light snowfall at a few places of the high hilly and mountainous region of the country.

Expected Temp.: 15 - 17°C
Rain Probability: ...%

Thursday's Weather Record

Stations	Max. temp. (C)	Min. temp. (C)	Rain (mm)
Dadeldhura	14.9	1.7	0.0
Dipayal	22.0	0.8	0.0
Dhangadi	19.5	1.8	0.0
Birendranagar	21.3	2.0	0.0
Nepalgunj	13.9	4.7	0.0
Jumla	12.3	-4.4	0.0
Ghorahi	20.7	5.0	0.0
Pokhara	19.9	5.7	0.0
Bhairahawa	12.1	8.3	0.0
Simara	12.2	9.5	0.0
Kathmandu	16.6	3.0	0.0
Okhaldhunga	15.8	4.7	0.0
Taplejung	14.7	2.8	0.0
Dhankuta	20.4	6.8	0.0
Biratnagar	18.0	8.6	0.0
Jomsom	7.0	-6.5	0.0*
Dharan	18.0	7.0	0.0*
Lumle	14.5	2.8	0.0*
Janakpur	18.2	8.6	0.0*
Jiri	12.7	0.6	0.0*

NEPAL RASTRA BANK

FOREIGN EXCHANGE DEPARTMENT

EXCHANGE RATES

January 26, 2024

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
Indian Rupee	100	Rs. 160.00	Rs. 160.15

Open Market Exchange Rates
For the purpose of Nepal Rastra Bank

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
U.S. Dollar	1	Rs. 132.69	Rs. 133.29
Euro	1	Rs. 144.49	Rs. 145.14
Pound Sterling	1	Rs. 168.87	Rs. 169.63
Swiss Franc	1	Rs. 153.43	Rs. 154.12
Australian Dollar	1	Rs. 87.43	Rs. 87.82
Canadian Dollar	1	Rs. 98.25	Rs. 98.69
Singapore Dollar	1	Rs. 99.03	Rs. 99.48
Japanese Yen	10	Rs. 8.99	Rs. 9.03
Chinese Yuan	1	Rs. 18.51	Rs. 18.59
Saudi Arab Riyal	1	Rs. 35.38	Rs. 35.54
Qatari Riyal	1	Rs. 36.41	Rs. 36.57
Thai Bhat	1	Rs. 3.72	Rs. 3.73
UAE Dirham	1	Rs. 36.13	Rs. 36.29
Malaysian Ringgit	1	Rs. 28.04	Rs. 28.17
South Korean Won	100	Rs. 9.93	Rs. 9.97
Swedish Kronar	1	Rs. 12.73	Rs. 12.78
Danish Kronar	1	Rs. 19.38	Rs. 19.47
Hong Kong Dollar	1	Rs. 16.97	Rs. 17.05
Kuwaiti Dinar	1	Rs. 431.37	Rs. 433.32
Bahrain Dinar	1	Rs. 351.99	Rs. 353.58

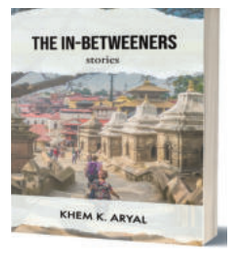
Note: Under the present system the open market exchange rates quoted by different banks may differ.

Published by Executive Chairman **Bishnu Prasad Subedi** and General Manager **Lal Bahadur Airi** for the Gorkhapatra Corporation • Printed at G.S. Press, Kathmandu • Acting Editor-in-Chief: **Bhimsen Thapaliya**
Phone: Editorial 5322279 • Advertisement 5327493, 5331394 • Distribution 5320638 • E-mail: mgorkhapatra@gmail.com, trnfeatures@hotmail.com • Registered No. 29/028/022 • G.P.O. 30/053/54



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THE RISING NEPAL
Friday
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Friday, January 26, 2024
risingnepaldaily.com

Arunachal: A Sweet Connection With Nepalis



Namrata Sharma

"Number one, we look like Nepalis. We are with Nepalis at home and in the jungles, and there are many Nepalis in Arunachal Pradesh," says Tokbom Borang, owner of the NEFA Orange farm in Dambuk, Arunachal Pradesh. Borang stated that the Arunachalis trust Nepalis because they don't lie. "Maybe out of 100, one or two drink or do otherwise, but 80 per cent of the Nepalis are very trustworthy. Indian citizens here and are very much respected, so I like Nepalis very much," he continued. Then, to my surprise, he started singing an old but popular Nepali song, 'Kanchi re Kanchi'. Borang told me that he enjoyed watching movies featuring Manisha Koirala and conversed a bit with me in workable Nepali. I met Borang at his orange orchid during my trip when I was invited to participate in the Orange Festival of Music and Adventure (OFAM) at Dambuk in the Dibang Valley of Arunachal Pradesh during December 14–18, 2023. There, I was pleasantly surprised to meet several Arunachalis who like Nepal and Nepalis a lot.

During the inauguration of the festival, I had the opportunity to interview Pema Khandu, the Chief Minister of Arunachal Pradesh (AP). "There is a Buddha connection between Nepal and Arunachal Pradesh, so we can develop tourism through the Buddhist circuit," said Pema. He emphasised the fact that PM Narendra Modi's policies have helped a lot in the development of the eight north-eastern states of India.

The geographical location of Arunachal Pradesh and its cultural environment are very similar to those of Thailand, Myanmar, other north-eastern states of India, and even eastern Nepal. Therefore, India's Arunachal Pradesh has a lot of similarities with South Asia and South-east Asia. Arunachal Pradesh is landlocked and has snow-capped mountains, hills, and rivers like the Brahmaputra, which captivate the minds of nature lovers and spiritually inclined people. It is the state where the sun rays touch the Indian soil earliest every morning and is known as the Land of the Dawn-lit Mountains. It lies on the north-eastern tip of India, bordering China, Bhutan, and Myanmar. It is, in fact, one of the remotest states in India.

The orange festival, which was started in 2015 as a tourism development strategy, has been taking place every year since then. This has positively impacted the promotion of tourism in the state. CM Khandu says that many programmes have been organised in Arunachal through the Prime Minister's Tourism Development and Dindayal Upadhyay Schemes. He said that Dambuk produced the sweetest oranges possible, and thus their focus was to export these oranges outside India. The festival helps in promoting the export of oranges and also in welcoming guests from other parts of India and other countries to boost the tourism of the state.

There are now more than 50 orange plantations in Arunachal Pradesh. Orange production is also good in Dambuk, Kameng, Lohit, and Suyang. Such festivals have helped to make the local oranges famous even abroad. Chief Minister Khandu said that the current Prime Minister's Northeast policy has brought about a big change in the roads and physical infrastructure of Arunachal. He said that in addition to receiving a lot of support from the centre for the development of the province, the local people have also started investing.

During my visit to the NEFA Orange Orchid, its owner, Tokbom Borang, informed me that he had earned one crore rupees by spending 14–15 lakhs in his orchard, which was started in 2018. "In nine years, I have been earning and recovering. "I hire fewer people, mainly women's groups and youth. They benefit from me and I from them; I have not taken any loans, but the government helped me set up my orange farm," says Borang. He mentioned that the Orange Festival was essential, and they had to acknowledge the contribution of Abu Tayeng, who came up with the idea of this festival. Before this festival, the people's economies were different. Now many youths have started growing oranges in big or small amounts, and they are earning. Borang mentioned that he exported oranges twice last year.

The buyer came to his garden with 200–300 labourers and took the oranges on 27 trucks. It took him one month to complete the task of plucking oranges from his garden. The oranges were exported to Dubai. He claims that NEFA Garden is the largest orange producer in the Northeast. "I have 4200 orange trees in my garden, and I earned 47 lakhs this year, which is a higher yield than a garden run by another farmer with 9000 trees," he proudly mentioned. 'It is very difficult to work in such a difficult geographical area. I could have gone elsewhere to look for opportunities, but here the government has encouraged orange cultivation, and I stayed on to do exactly that', says Boranag.

Lakhpa Tsering, the President of the Motor Sports Club of Arunachal Pradesh and one of the organisers of OFAM, shared his experience of hosting a festival in the north-eastern tip of India. "When we started the Orange Festival with Abu Tayeng as the director of the festival, this place was like Kalapani, which was forever cut off physically from all other regions of India. That time there were no roads, so we thought of doing off-roading events, but since then and now, the same area that needed hours to be reached can be reached in minutes, so we have started motor road races too," says Lakhpa. He further added that the NE was totally neglected earlier, but the BJP government is bringing airports, railway stations, and roads with accountability to the people of this region. He mentioned that the education system was also improving with more colleges like the NITs.

Lakhpa's family is known to own one of the best wineries in India. "Our winery is a family business that was possible to get started only because of government policies, and I can happily tell you that it is doing well, and we sell it to other parts of India," he said. His wines are produced from apples, kiwi, and honey ginger, all sourced from Arunachal. He says that Nepal, having the Himalayas, has mountain people, and the commonality with people from Arunachal is that we are all people with good hearts who need to work hard for our livelihoods.

The construction of the Dr. Bhupen Hazarika Bridge, inaugurated by Narendra Modi in 2017, drastically changed life in Arunachal Pradesh. This is known as a major bridge between Dhola and Sadias Ghats. This bridge joins Assam and Arunachal Pradesh, and the people of the two states feel that initiatives like these have helped in resolving land disputes between the two states and also provided a beam of hope for the people of the Northeastern states to build their economies and have more mobility within the region and the country. This bridge is the first permanent road connection between northern Assam and eastern Arunachal Pradesh. It is 9.15 km in length and is now the longest bridge in India. It has been designed to handle heavy-weight tanks. This bridge has also helped boost tourism in the region.

Apart from focusing on oranges, the festival also transformed the town of Dambuk into a vibrant hub of culture, adventure, and music. The festival was organised by the state and central government for the eighth consecutive year to enhance the production of oranges in the northeastern state. In order to make the function lively, bands such as Apache from the UK, Bombay Vi King, and POD also performed in Dambuk.

Abu Tyeng, the Secretary of Sports and Youth and Tourism Department of the province, is credited with starting Dambuk's orange festival and promoting tourism. The son of the first IAS officer of Arunachal Pradesh, he is also an IAS officer and is involved in the development of the province. Tyeng is another Arunachali who has a soft corner for Nepal and the Nepali community of Indian citizens.

He said that he has many Nepali friends, and they grew up together. As Nepali songs are very popular in Arunachal, he said that in the past, several Nepali bands were invited to perform at the Dambuk Orange Festival, and they were loved by the people there.

Many provinces in India have a presence of migrant Nepalis. Many people like Nepalis in Arunachal Pradesh. Nepalis here are involved in various professions. There are also Nepali speakers from Arunachal and Assam who are responsible for the arrangement of food at the festival, the management of issues like homestays, and 'event management'.

'Rafting and road motor rallies, which are popular with tourists, are becoming popular here,' says Anand Tsering, vice president of the Motor Sports Club of Arunachal Pradesh. Tsering is an Assamese Indian of Nepali origin. He is also a successful 'fast car racer' and champion. He, along with several other Nepali-origin Indians, are important pillars of the festival.

Nepal can learn from the development of tourism and the promotion of local produce in Arunanchal. Dambuk is located in the Diwang Valley of Arunachal Pradesh. This is the least-populated district in India. Nepal has excellent production of apples and oranges in places like Jumla, Gorkha, Dhankuta, and elsewhere. Recently, it has been seen that macadamia nuts and kiwi can also be grown, provided proper care is given. The government here, too, has policies encouraging the production and marketing of local produce. Gorkha's oranges and Jumla's apples can be internationalised in the style of Arunachal's oranges. The leadership there has won the hearts and votes of the people by developing the state. In Dambuk, where there were no hotels before 2015, now homestays and resorts have emerged.

Arunachal Pradesh and other Northeast states of India bear a lot of similarities with Nepal. Many of them have 20 to 30 per cent Nepali-origin residents who are settled there and feel very proud of the fact that they are Indians, but they maintain their Nepali culture and heritage. OFAM includes adventures involving off-road driving, zip lines, gas balloon rides, river rafting, trekking, and cultural and traditional dances. These are sports, except for gas balloon rides, that are popular in Nepal too. Therefore, a collaboration between Arunachal Pradesh and Nepal could be a possibility in the future.

The Ministry of Tourism should make favourable policies for promoting tourism all over Nepal, which has huge potential in the tourism sector. Besides hydroelectric projects, the government is lacking in promoting agro-tourism, which has a high potential and rate of return for Nepal and Nepalis. This could generate huge employment opportunities for the Nepali youths who are migrating at record rates to the Middle East, Malaysia, and elsewhere at great risk to their lives. The Nepali youths who have plans to migrate abroad and work, for example, in orange or apple orchids, should be encouraged to start their own enterprises with support from the central and provincial governments.After a few days in Arunachal, one returns with a lot of spiritual, mental, and physical well-being. The pristine beauty of the Northeastern Tip of India has the potential to steal the hearts of all who visit.

(The author is a senior journalist and women's rights advocate.)







Photo: Sarad Verma

Policy Dilemma In Agriculture Sector



Sagar Ghimire



The transformation of agriculture has been the most discussed issue in Nepal, marked by notable shifts in the dynamics of factors of production, including land, labour, and capital markets. The predominant goals of agricultural policies have consistently centred on modernization, commercialization, and mechanisation, aiming to propel the sector into a more contemporary and efficient state. The government's policy also envisions enhancing productivity, improving crops through breeding, ensuring input availability, and providing market assurance. In the course of modernization, issues such as germplasm maintenance, ecological agriculture, conservation of landraces, high-value crop plantation, and climate-smart agriculture are also gaining importance. Political concern has also increased regarding the growing trend of food imports. The once self-sufficient country in major staple foods is now becoming a net importer.

Due to the scarcity of factors of production, we must acknowledge that being self-sufficient in all products is not feasible. However, we can make proper crop choices to achieve sufficiency in strategic crops. Yet, unanswered questions persist concerning crop selection. What crop should I cultivate on my small parcel of land? Should I cultivate paddy to feed my family, or should I consider vegetables, fruits, or other cash crops? If I choose paddy, should I cultivate local landraces with lower productivity for better quality, or should I go for improved or hybrid paddy to increase production? Should I rely on organic production, or should I pursue inorganic farming? These are serious dilemmas in the mindset of farmers before cultivation. However, the decisions made by farmers at the household level against these dilemmas continuously impact the food production status and agricultural trade potential of the country.

Additionally, what recommendations does the government provide for farmers in specific regions? Is the government promoting crops with trade potential, or is it focusing on major staple food crops for self-sufficiency and subsistence? What has been envisioned by our policies? What could be the best decision for sustainable agricultural development and food security? The middle way between self-sufficiency and trade, and subsequent adjustments based on the extent of influence by advocates, has been the common practice in planning and budgeting for decades. This scenario is responsible for the uncontrolled and unnatural behaviour and shifts in crop choice, production, productivity, land abandonment, and farmers' migration.



The policy dilemma is observed between achieving self-sufficiency in major staple food crops like paddy, maize, etc., or focusing on the production of cash crops and tradable commodities, leveraging advantages from microclimates and agrobiodiversity. There is a need to increase the production and productivity of major staple food crops for self-sufficiency and food security. However, the system requires government subsidies and support in both production and marketing to enhance its competitive capacity in the changing scenario of labour shortages and increased cultivation costs. On the other hand, opting for cash crops and tradable or exportable commodities is more likely to yield premium prices and enhance competitive capacity. Perennial cropping appears to be a strategy employed by farmers to combat labor shortages. The increasing trend of peri-urban vegetable farming, establishing perennial fruit orchards, and cultivating exportable commodities like tea, coffee, cardamom, etc. can be observed as evidence of this transformation. However, both farmers and government policies seem to be stuck in a puzzle when it comes to making crop choices.

Our agricultural policies appear to be well-documented, covering a comprehensive range of agricultural issues and promoting various commodities and sectors without leaving anyone behind. For instance, our policies outline the promotion of both organic agriculture and chemical fertiliser use, endorsing hybrid varieties as well as indigenous landraces for all crops without specifying the applicable areas. However, we lack a concrete action plan for the classification of areas and budget allocation within the sector, even in the face of contradicting issues. It seems that we are content with providing material subsidies to farmers based on their requests. Consequently, agricultural development programmes seem more like political initiatives aimed at attracting votes than genuine efforts to promote agriculture. Unfortunately, we find ourselves delayed in addressing contradicting issues, such as promoting maize production and protecting monkeys in the same geographical region. These issues call for urgent action through policy review, with a focus on developing a concrete action plan and allocating fiscal resources proportionately. Recognising that a single idea cannot be universally applicable in our diverse context, it is imperative that we do not delay in deciding our priorities for specific interventions, strategic action plans, and collaborative efforts.

In the emerging trend of migration and non-farm employment opportunities, farmers can no longer sustain themselves at a subsistence level or below. Our farming population is ageing, and successors are not readily available in the rural community due to the limited appeal of agriculture, primarily because of its subsistence nature and various associated risks. The comparative and competitive advantages have deteriorated over time due to the reduced scale of production resulting from land fragmentation. Nevertheless, the increased availability of inputs and technology and the development of infrastructure such as irrigation and road networks have enhanced opportunities for the sector's development.

For example, at the national level, self-sufficiency in major staple food grains like paddy is an important parameter for food security and is also a matter of nationality and sovereignty. Self-sufficiency in rice is pivotal for measuring the sufficiency of the agriculture sector. In those conditions, we should not be behind in intervening in rice production. Limiting the low-yielding local landraces to protection level only, we must concentrate on the use of hybrids and improved varieties along with research and development. The rice crop demands a special structure of land with irrigation facilities, so our policy must include an action plan to classify and protect rice land. This is crucial because the threat to rice land often arises more from within the agriculture sector due to shifts in crop choices than from outside the sector. Recognising the criticality and ultimate importance of rice due to food habits, rice producers must be prioritised for fertiliser distribution, mechanisation, seed replacement, automatic insurance services, and support prices.

Thus, considering budget constraints, government intervention must prioritise limited and strategic commodities to show positive results in achieving self-sufficiency and trade benefits. Identifying tradable crops that fetch premium prices and possess competitive capacity is crucial and should be promoted without compromising the areas dedicated to major staple food crop production. The haphazard crop choices by farmers, as well as the disorganized programming and budgeting by different tiers of government, need to be regulated by the federal ministry. The current federal political structure requires a comprehensive agricultural policy that serves as a guideline for all tiers of government. Urgent measures are required to halt the trend of public consumption-driven decisions following fashionable emerging commodities and try new approaches every year without a concrete analysis of the impact of policy and programmes for publicity. There is a need for clarity in policies and action plans. Maintaining coherence and consistency in agricultural development policies and fiscal programmes across all tiers of government is essential for striking the right balance between self-sufficiency and trade in agriculture, a key factor in ensuring sustainable agricultural development.

The author is an Agriculture Extension Officer, Gandaki Province.

Beauty Standards Impact Gender Equality



Shreena Nepal



How beauty brands have been corrupting the mindset of the entire world, Nomi Wolf says in her book 'The Beauty Myth', "the quality called beauty objectively and universally exists. Women must want to embody it, and men must want to possess women who embody it." The author brings to light an important issue that plagues women: body insecurity. This insecurity has such a significant impact on women's mental well-being that it leads to a host of issues, such as depression, anxiety, and other related problems. The prevalence of eating disorders among women is also a matter of concern, with studies indicating that women are more likely to suffer from such disorders than men, with anorexia nervosa being one of the most well-known disorders. People suffering from this disorder tend to believe that they are overweight, even if they are underweight. It generally develops during adolescence or young adulthood and tends to affect more women than men.

This perfect body image has been enshrined in everyone's mind in such a way that it's difficult to even be body-positive. Even in almost all of the images of gods and goddesses, there's a perfect body with pretty faces. Well, those pictures are a reflection of society. Jane Dipika Garrett became the first plus-sized candidate representing Nepal to compete for Miss Universe 2023. Well, it took 71 years to accept the fact that beauty pageants must not be made just about the so-called perfect body. Well, Miss Universe is defying the standards by allowing transwomen, mothers, and divorcees to participate in the competition. Miss World, on the other hand, has no such realisation. Well, we are now celebrating what should have been normal. These beauty standards exist only for women to make them insecure about themselves and lose confidence in doing anything other than maintaining themselves.

Structural violence manifests in various forms, including gender-based discrimination in various aspects of life. Women, for instance, are often paid less than men for the same job. They may also be overlooked for certain job opportunities, particularly those that require physical labor. However, in certain professions, such as air hostess or receptionist, women with attractive features may be preferred. Krishna Abiral, in his book Laal Chudi, mentioned how society controls women's entire lives and limits their lives to just getting married. He portrayed only one story about society.

In 2016, the International Labour Organisation (ILO) and Gallup conducted a survey to find out whether women across the world preferred to work in paid employment, take care of their families, or do both. The survey results were surprising, as they revealed that 70 per cent of women, regardless of their employment status, preferred to work in paid employment. Looking at the status of Nepal from the same research, 56 per cent of women desired to work in paid employment, whereas only 21 per cent of women had worked in paid employment. According to the same research, in terms of workforce participation rates, women lag significantly behind men globally. The current statistics indicate that the participation rate for women is almost 25 per cent lower than that of men. This disparity is more pronounced in certain regions, where the difference exceeds 50 percentage points.

A girl in her stand-up comedy mentioned that if a period was to happen to a male, they would have made an extremely big deal about it. If they would get periods, we would be celebrating "period day." There would be a period minister and a PMS relief fund. They would be very understanding about each other having periods. Can you believe the government imposes a tax on sanitary pads? The state really expects girls under the age of 10 to pay taxes to the government. Well, the reality was only heard because she made it sound hilarious. If you ask any woman who bleeds if she would want to, if it was an option, then mark these words: not a single woman wants to bleed. Governments have been exempting the tax on condoms, considering it one of the most basic needs and important from a reproductive health perspective. Well, menstruation is one of the main reasons for reproduction; it is not even a choice; it doesn't have a withdrawal option. So all these laws, rules, and regulations are more inclined towards the betterment of men.

Feminism isn't responsible for double responsibility. It's a dominant mindset that refuses to take responsibility for household work. As women, we promote learning household chores as a basic human need. Every individual should possess fundamental survival skills. The notion that a woman is lucky to have a husband who helps with housework is outdated. We should be concerned that our husbands and sons lack awareness of these essential human needs.

If males are to be males, if males every man thinks nothing apart from sex, as published by Professor Sheridan Simove, which soon became the best seller, why are women blamed for being rape victims? If males cannot keep their hands to themselves and if men can't control themselves, isn't it absurd to think that they can control the nation and the world?

Few women globally are successful because only a handful have been given a fair chance. A woman is seen as incomplete without marriage, and if she pursues a career, she must prioritise household duties first.

We have always asked instead of fighting for even our basic needs! We have worked tirelessly to distance ourselves from being labelled as a weaker section of society. We have fought for our property rights, our citizenship rights, and our right to choose when it comes to abortion. We have also fought for the exemption of tax on sanitary pads, recognising that it is a basic necessity for women. We have demanded equal pay for equal work and equal opportunities for all. We have stood up against violence in all its forms, refusing to be silenced. Although some of our rights have been codified, many still remain unacknowledged and unenforced. Despite this, we continue to fight daily for our rights and for a fair and just society.

Every year, from November 25th to December 10th, a global campaign against gender-based violence is conducted. Various organisations arrange awareness programmes, advocacy is done worldwide, different international and national conferences are held, and individuals come together, even if it is through their social media platforms. However, the sad part is that the campaign ends on December 10th, and people wait for another year to do something about it. As the new year begins, my resolution is to remind everyone time and again to take practical steps to end gender disparity.

The words of William Shakespeare resonate deeply when it comes to bringing about change. "Nothing changes if nothing changes" may seem like an oversimplification, but it is a reminder that taking action is necessary to achieve progress. Consistency, perseverance, and core values are key to ending inequality. We must unite, collaborate, and use our unique skills and perspectives to make progress. Let's keep moving forward, no matter how hard the road ahead.

(The author is pursuing BA.LLB. at Kathmandu School of Law)

Khem K. Aryal's In-Between Sway



Gopi Sapkota

It was 1995 or may be 1996. You tend to be forgetful, or you would not care, when you are over fifty. It does not really matter if you miss a year when you are counting the years from your past.

Having wandered on campus corridors for a while looking for my classroom, I recall, I entered Room Number 11, where some 30 or 40 semi-attentive students listened to a lecturer, whom I would later know as Anita Dhungel. It was my first day of class as an M.A. student at Ratna Rajyalaxmi Campus.

On that day, I didn't know two things would happen in the future. First, out of those 40 unknown faces, I would find Nirmala and marry her; and second, I would make a decades-long friendship with Khem K. Aryal and write about him following the publication of his book in the United States, something we didn't hope could happen to us one day.

In the last 27–28 years of our friendship, you can't imagine how many hours we must have spent discussing writing, publishing, recognition, publicity, contribution to Nepali literature, and what not.

One day, during the early years of our friendship, one interesting incident happened. Khem invited me to his rented room for tea. It was a decent-size room, painted in light yellow, with a small book rack in a corner. When I was scanning the room, I saw a painting hanging on the wall over the book rack, signed by the artist as Kumar Shishir.

It was a familiar name to me. I asked Khem whether he knew the painter. He smiled and asked me back, 'Do you know him?'

I said I knew him by his name, but I didn't know him personally.

He smiled again, and I sensed that he himself could be the artist.

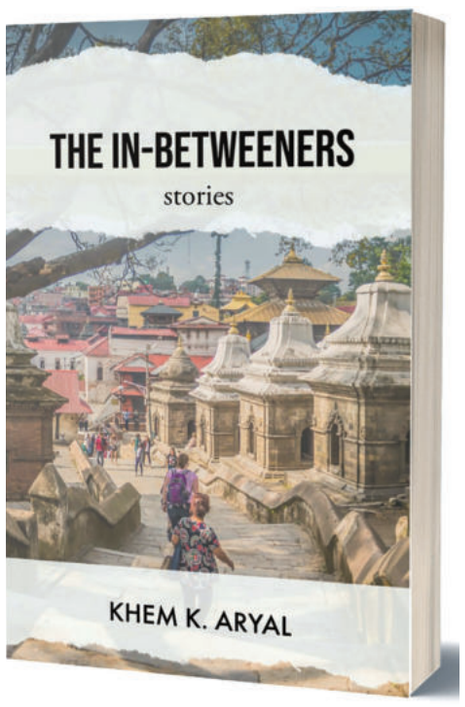
I asked, 'Are you the artist?'

He laughed, and then both of us did.

At that point, Khem had already published a collection of Nepali poems under his pen name, Kumar Shishir. His stories were getting published in Nepal's prestigious literary journals like Madhuparka and Mirmire.

As we were completing our master's degree, I could see that he was getting more into English writing while I continued to write in Nepali, though I did write in English too occasionally. Both of us were getting more serious about writing while struggling to find a space in the literary landscape of Kathmandu.

It was an interesting period in Nepali English writing. After the restoration of democracy in 1990, new English publications and English-medium schools were burgeoning, and the demand for English writing and venues to share English writing were increasing. Under the guidance of senior writers and professors, such as Padma Devktoa and Shreedhar Lohani, we founded an organisation, the Society of Nepali Writers in English (NWEN), in 2000 to promote English writing from Nepal. Khem was nominated as its president, and I became secretary. This resulted in monthly meetings in which we mostly shared poems, the publication of Nepalese clay, and liaison with English newspapers to publish creative writing pieces in their weekly supplements. These spaces encouraged writers to write in English as well as to translate Nepali writing into English. As president, Khem led the organisation's efforts very effectively, and we remained close collaborators until 2007, when I migrated to the UK and Khem was planning to pursue his Ph.D. in the United States.



During those NWEN days, Khem's two English poetry collections, Kathmandu Saga and Other Poems and Epic Teashop, were published in Kathmandu. He took the lead in publishing Of Nepalese Clay and co-edited it with Professors Padma Devkota and Hriseekesh Upadhyay for seven years. Most of the Nepalese writers writing in English were featured in the journal. The journal was also instrumental in grooming many new writers in English.

Samrat Upadhyay and Manjushree Thapa were our idols back then. Samrat's debut short story collection, Arresting God in Kathmandu, which won him the Whiting Award, and Manjushree Thapa's the Tutor of History were creating a big buzz among English readers in Kathmandu, which inspired all of us. We too dreamt of publishing our books in English from the United States or the United Kingdom one day, though that one day didn't dawn anywhere on the visible horizon.

I decided at one point, though, that I would not bother about writing in English. I was making my space in Nepali writing, with books published from the Nepal Academy and Ratna Pustak Bhandar, which were considered top publishing venues those days. I continued to concentrate on Nepali writing, whereas Khem continued writing in English. His dedication, passion, and belief in himself have finally led to the publication of a collection of his stories, The In-Betweeners, by an American publishing house, Braddock Avenue Books, and that makes me feel that the dream we shared long ago has come true. I cannot be happier for him and for Nepali writing in English as a whole.

The number of Nepali writers writing in English is growing, both within and outside Nepal, but we have yet to see writers of significance since Upadhyay and Thapa. I genuinely hope that the publication of The In-Betweeners will be just the beginning for Khem.

Khem is a happy person in life, but when it comes to writing, he is never satisfied. The time and effort he invests in editing, crafting, and revising amazes me. It seems that he enjoys the process of writing more than the writing itself. I am envious of his patience in waiting for the publication. I remember that a novel he wrote about twenty years ago was accepted by a small publisher in Delhi, but he stepped back and never got it published.

In terms of subject matter, Khem deals with socio-political and family issues. He picks up simple but somehow weird characters from society, observes and examines them closely, and crafts their stories in carefully designed plots with artistic details, most of the time playing with their ambivalent mental states.

On the surface, the stories in The In-Betweeners are stories of Nepali immigrants in the USA, struggling to establish themselves in the new abode while still thinking of their life back in Nepal. However, you delve into them more, and the stories will open new windows to understanding human predicaments in general. I feel that these stories are more than just the stories of in-betweeners, or they make me feel that all of us are in-betweeners. They deal with human weaknesses and resilience, and they deal with the personal and social absurdities we are all part of.

Khem's stories are unique as they deal with seemingly mundane issues that most of us don't even think of writing about. While reading some of his stories, you may get irritated with his characters and feel like shouting at them for not sorting out even a minor problem. The main character in "Shopping for Glasses" suffers for a long time simply because he is unable to decide which frames to choose and the shopkeepers are not forcing him to buy any, unlike in Nepal. The stories feel so deep that readers will find it hard to come out of the fictional well that the writer has dug. I think that's the success of a writer. I wish The In-Betweeners a big success.

(Sapkota is a poet and playwright.)

> The stories in the In-Betweeners are stories of Nepali immigrants in the USA, struggling to establish themselves in the new abode.

FUTURE WATCH

(Based on birth names)

January 26th to February 1st 2024 - D. N. Lohani

ARIES — Initially, you may have to endure a health disorder. Circumstances will gradually improve. The study will gradually improve. Doubts and confusion can reside within oneself. Undertaken assignments will be completed successfully.

TAURUS — An ordinary day is in store for you. Health disorders are likely to slow down. It is likely to defer progress. Lack of support from others can cause challenges. Study-related expenses will rise.

GEMINI — Undertaken assignments will be completed successfully. Your opponents will succeed in delaying your progress. Business-related travel will occur. The health concerns of the family will increase expenses.

CANCER — An entertaining week is in the store. Initially, celebrations or similar events will occur. Financial status will remain ordinary. Major tasks will be completed successfully. Foreign travel is probable.

LEO — Initially, expenditure levels will rise. Celebrations or similar events will occur. You will find it difficult to save. Support provided by friends will guide you ahead. Trade will yield an ordinary return.

VIRGO — The expenditure level will rise. The technical line will turn profitable. Students will have to work harder. Indecisiveness can create some problems. Memory loss can cause some concern.

LIBRA — Social prestige won't rise. Regular gains will help consolidate your financial position. Work will keep you busy and yield a return. You will be keen to learn new trades. The task will be completed after causing expenses on Tuesday.

SCORPIO — Major tasks will be completed successfully. You will be eager to complete philanthropic assignments. Financial status will improve. You may have to handle a new venture. Business will fascinate you.

SAGITTARIUS — The expenditure level will rise. You may have to handle numerous challenges. Anxiety can arise on Friday. Doubts and confusion can reside within oneself. Circumstances will improve on Thursday. Business will yield ordinary gains. Study will take a progressive course.

CAPRICORN — Uncertainty can arise. Talks about travel can be held. Pilgrimage is probable. Doubts and confusion can reside within oneself. A health disorder is predicted. Educational expenses will rise. Anxiety can arise on Monday.

AQUARIUS — Though expenditure levels won't go down, important assignments will be completed successfully. Social prestige will rise. Distant friends will cooperate. The family will help. You may hear unpleasant news on Wednesday.

PISCES — An advantageous week is in the store. You will experience a busy schedule. Financial status will improve. profession will yield a return. Don't expect much support from your family. Job-related problems can arise.

Stories That Propel Readers Beyond Expectation



BOOK REVIEW



Modnath Dhakal

Book: Andhyaro Kuno (collection of short stories) (2023) by Khagendra Bhattarai. Publisher: Sergem Prakashan Griha. Pages: 105. ISBN: 978-9937-1-3411-8. Price: Rs. 250 (US$5).

Nepali readers get a rare chance to come across a piece of literature that deals with sexuality and talks about the issues on the topic in the societies here. Sex is taboo, as is sexuality. People hesitate to talk about it, even with their doctors. There are many couples who don't talk about it openly, even in their private spaces. However, a good number of writers have tried to tread into this genre in Nepali literature. From Bishweshwor Prasad Koirala to Saru Bhakta, Nepali literature has some precious gifts that deal with sexual psychology. Many critics consider Koirala's short story 'Chandra Badan' as an entry point to such a genre in Nepal. Saru Bhakta's 'Taruni Kheti' is a novel that talks about sexuality in imagery, similes, and metaphor, without which it would have just remained low-grade pulp fiction sold at the bus stands. Sita Pandey, Prashu Pradhan, Parijat, Krishna Dharabasi, Prema Shah, Daulat Bikram Bista, Bhawani Bhikshu, Tarini Prasad Koirala, Pushkar Lohani, Bijaya Pandey, and their other contemporaries have dealt with sexuality in their literary creations.

Khagendra Bhattarai has dared to continue the trend and picked issues from our surroundings to craft some beautiful short stories. His recent book, 'Andhyaro Kuno' (The Dark Corner), has hit the market and will certainly hit your senses as well.

It has been quite a while since Nepali literature received a creation like this, delving directly into the arena of sexual psychology and bringing issues that are of utmost importance but less talked about to the readers. Sexuality is a part of human nature. In societies that are typical of South Asia, people use symbols while talking or communicating about sexuality or talk in a way that one has to read between the lines to get the meaning. For example, Lakshimaya didi (sister) in 'Sallako Rukh' has a pine tree, planted by her husband, in her courtyard. Her husband dies in the armed conflict, and she wants the tree to fall on her. She says the tree slowly sings and teases her. It is a strong metaphor for 'sex' as a woman wants something to press her or crush her!

'Sallako Rukh' story is a strong representation of the Maoist-led armed conflict as well. This story talks about the brutality of the guerillas cutting the vocal cords of their comrades who were severely wounded in the attack or landmine blast. Fighters who lost their body parts in the attack would shriek bitterly in agony, which would terrify others and discourage them from fighting the war. So, a special team would cut out their vocal cords.

The book has fourteen stories that deal with sexual psychology. A couple of them have found their setting in the decade-long armed conflict. The author has used the language of everyday people, which has made the stories more authentic, and readers will immediately relate to them. Boys in the story address a beautiful girl as 'maal' (goods).

'Phulawa' is a story about the divide between people from the Tarai and Hill regions. The setting of the story is familiar, and readers will quickly understand that it is the story of a 'Pahadiya (people from the hills) master' teaching in a school in the Tarai region of the country.

About a year and a half ago, the divide was stark. The communal hatred culminated in the Gaur Massacre, where 17 Maoist cadres were brutally killed. It highlighted the ethnic and regional tensions in the plains. However, 'Phulawa' presents a better side of humanity. Top of Form

The first story of the book, 'Leela', presents the setting of a school in a typical underdeveloped village and less-sensitive teachers who control their students like a shepherd controls his sheep. Many Nepalis who completed their primary-level education at a school in a remote village surely have experienced somewhat the same situation. Without showing any sexual behaviour or a crime, the author has vilified 'Gopi Guru'. When the story comes to an end, readers don't want to halt there and begin to further the story out of their own creativity.

Khagendra takes his readers on a journey of mixed reactions in 'Thatta'. The readers may smile, sympathise (or empathise), enrage, or laugh when they read a story bearing an anecdote about a man who takes goat medicines and never grows taller than a 'he goat'. 'Malai Surahi Banaideu' (turn me into a water jar) is another powerful metaphor for suppressed sexual desires. The story ends so suddenly that the reader feels a punch and waits for a while to get more to read. It seems that the author knows where to end his tales so that his readers will be challenged to think beyond it.

Every story in the book forces you to think beyond its ending. The author has given an abrupt ending to his creations at such a point that you might close the book for a while and just wonder what could have happened after that. Some contemplations will surely amuse you, while others might surprise you. The stories in the book will surely shake your long-held belief or fortify it. They will tell everyone about the sexuality of the 'opposite sex'.

The author has made a significant contribution to Nepali literature with the publication of this book. Readers will get a chance to have a new taste with' sexuality spices' and might get an opportunity to peep into a part of society that they wouldn't have explored otherwise. The book can be read in one sitting, but you should consume it slowly to digest it fully.

Unsafe Referees Of Nepali Sports



Rajanbikram Prajapati

Referees are responsible for the general supervision of the game and have the final authority on all rulings. A referee is assisted by other officials in the game. The number of supporting officials varies according to the rules of different games. They are known by several other titles as well, including judge, umpire, linesman, arbitrator, timekeeper, and technical official. Their responsibilities usually include starting or stopping the game whenever necessary and resolving infractions of game standards. Before starting the game, they may check the equipment to ensure that it adheres to safety standards and game regulations.

It is said that a good referee should not be seen; they are constantly under a microscope when they make decisions. As referees, they must be experts in rules. They must be perpetual students of their sports. They should be calm and confident, even when the crowd is loud. Confidence is the number-one skill a referee should have. If a referee doesn't have a high level of self-confidence, he or she is not going to do well. With every call a referee makes, it is necessary that they be confident, even if they are unsure of the call. Confidence is the key to a good referee, because if a referee starts questioning himself, then the players will notice that and begin to question the integrity of the referee itself.

Referees need quick observation skills, excellent concentration, patience, and the ability to thrive well under pressure. A referee has to watch the game carefully, track time, call out faults, and communicate with players and other officials. It's a challenging job, from passing the entry-level exam to advancing to higher levels, getting the best assignments, and doing a good job under pressure in a big game.

These are all challenges for every referee, and when these goals are met, it creates a great deal of satisfaction. Refereeing keeps the mind sharp. Whether you are a basketball referee moving along with the players or a volleyball umpire watching from a set location, acute mental focus is a must. Oftentimes, the mental demands can be much tougher than the physical demands.

In the context of refereeing in Nepal, academic qualifications aren't given much importance. But to be eligible for international refereeing, one must possess a basic level of English-speaking skills and other qualifications as well. As compared to other countries, we are very far behind in terms of resources and technology in various games.

Even though a referee is a crucial part of the game, they aren't given much respect in Nepal. The service, incentives, and facilities for referees are extremely limited. They themselves have to cover all the costs and airfares, excluding lodging and meals, even for a big international game while representing Nepal. The government should be taking care of these things as they have been doing for athletes; the government needs to set aside a platform, training, seminars, and equipment for referees as well.

Outside of international tournaments, their pay is very nominal. By doing only this job, they cannot sustain their lives. It seems like it is for pocket money only. It is also said that if you are in this job just for the money, you're in the wrong job. Of course, being a referee or umpire is not the primary means of employment for most. However, for a part-time job too, the rate of pay should be reasonable.

In a spectacular game, fans of the winning team feel joy, and those of the losing team feel sadness. And with sadness comes the need to place the blame on someone or something. The referee of the game often turns out to be an easy target of outrage. In many instances, teams and fans cite the reason they lost as poor officiating,



referencing the few mistakes they made during the game. No matter at what level, the referee is going to receive all the criticism if he or she makes a mistake, and one should be mentally ready to accept that. Even in friendly games, many participants harshly criticise referees for their calls.

There are several incidents in which the referee misbehaves during or after the match. Even in our national- or local-level games, we see such immoral activities time and again. In the 2079/80 Martyr's Memorial A Division League, the controversial match between Church Boys United and FC Khumaltar is an instance in which the referee got attacked by the players and officials. Referee Prajwal Chhetri gave red cards to four officials of Khumaltar after they attacked the referee for not giving a penalty in the injury time of the controversial first half. Such a situation repeated itself in the match between Sporting Ilam FC and Birgunj United FC of the Nepal Super League 2080. In the match, the goalkeeper got a red card after misbehaving with the referee. Security personnel protected the referee from the outraged players of Ilam FC.

Referees are also humans, so they can make mistakes. In the volleyball match between Nepal Police Club and Help Nepal Sports Club in the 3rd NVA Cup in 2016, it was blamed that the referee took the decisions looking at the supporters.

The referee had executed her decision, but she changed it. The organisers were helpless, and the hour-long break hampered the match rhythm. Instances of biassed decisions by referees and judges are not uncommon in Nepali sports. Personal affiliations, regional biases, and political interference often cloud the judgement of these officials. Such biases can be detrimental to the morale and motivation of the athletes.

Even in court, the judge withdraws from participation in a legal proceeding to avoid any appearance of bias or impropriety. But there are so many examples in Nepali sports where referees and judges are appointed from the same club. In such circumstances, spectators and athletes may have lower expectations of a fair decision. So in such cases, they should withdraw their name from a particular competition by themselves.

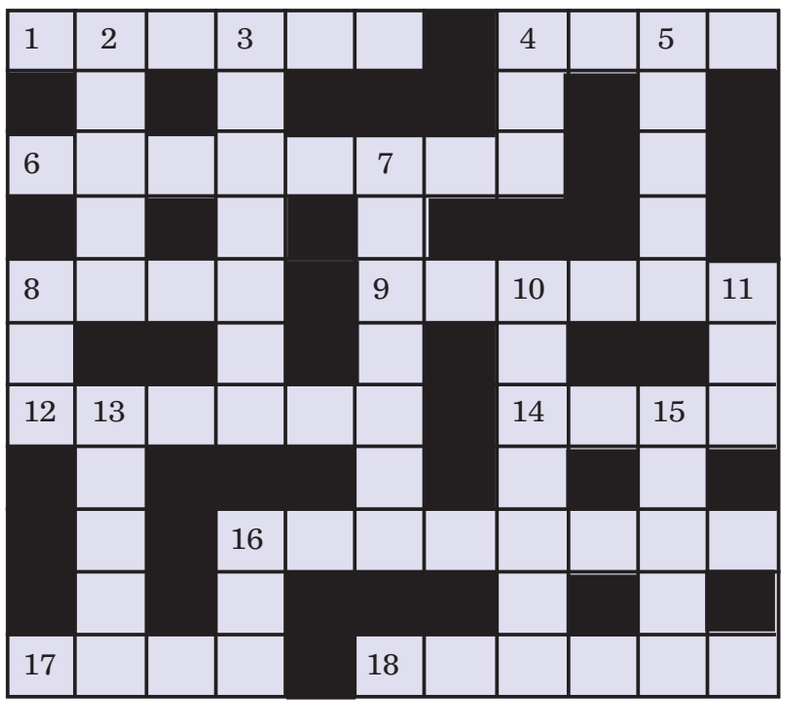
A significant contributing factor to the presence of unsafe referees and judges is the lack of accountability and transparency in the system. Inadequate oversight and regulation allow these officials to operate with impunity, evading punishment for their misconduct. Many coaches and players say that they are punished for misbehaviour, but there are no punitive measures for referees. So, there must be a good mechanism to monitor the decisions of referees as well. Unfair decisions and biassed officiating can demoralise athletes, hinder their progress, and discourage their participation in sports.

There must be comprehensive reform in the officiating system, including vetting procedures, regular training, certification programmes, and refreshment courses. And of course, there should be a responsible body for overseeing referees, which promotes transparency and accountability. Winning or losing is obvious in a game, but the referee's decisions should not hamper the player's confidence.

Definitely, referees cannot be beaten because of a decision they make, even if it's wrong. There should be other measures to penalise them. The unsafe state of referees in Nepali sports casts a dark shadow over the country's athletic achievements. By implementing robust reforms and promoting a culture of integrity in sports, we can ensure the fair, transparent, and conducive growth of athletes, where referees can also feel safe. The environment should be created where all referees get good respect and feel proud of being in this profession.

(The author is an International Boxing Association referee and former national boxer.)

TRN CROSSWORD PUZZLE NO. 1775



Name .....

Address .....

Signature .....

Last date of entry:
January 31, 2024

Win a prize of Rs. 600. In case there are more than one correct entry the prize will be split into three sums of Rs. 200 each. The winner will be selected by a lucky draw. Only cuttings (not photo copy) that include the Crossword Puzzle no. will be accepted.

Across
1. Annoying situation
4. Protracted fight
6. Reduced unpleasant feeling
8. Equal score (1, 3)
9. Remove from power
12. Delay the progress
14. A formal test
16. Large amount of foods
17. A medicine
18. What a thief does?

Down
2. Valuable thing
3. Force yourself into a car
4. An arbitrary like o dislike
5. To be of use
7. Lacking determination
8. A male friend
10. Clear and accurate
11. A type of tall tree
13. An army officer
15. Messenger of God
16. Official records of events

Solutions to TRN Crossword Puzzle No. 1774

ACROSS: 1. ADDICT 4. AVID 6. CONFLICT 8. NEWS 9. TETRYL 12. MADDEN 14. RAVE 16. OBEDIENT 17. PLOT 18. ASHMEN

DOWN: 2. DRONE 3. INFUSED 4. ACT 5. IMPLY 7. INTENSE 8. NAM 10. TARNISH 11. LIE 13. ANNUL 15. VENUE 16. OPT

LUCKY WINNER

Archana Devi Shrestha
Damodar Lohani
Kumari Nirmala Giri

ALL CORRECT ANSWER

Mahendra Kumari Nath, Krishna Chandra Gautam, Sheela Shrestha, Rekha Rajopadhyaya, Khagendra Nath, Bal Krishna Shrestha, Surya Shakya, Mana Raja Rajopadhyaya, Sunil Sharma Bhattarai

CREATIVE CORNER

My Snow Adventure



Zoya Ranjan



My name is Zoya, and I want to talk about snow today. It's cool. I love snow. I made a snowman, and we will finish it tomorrow. Let's start from the beginning. I was told there would be snow for the New Year's Day. There was no snow. I wanted snow! A few days later, snow came, and I was happy.

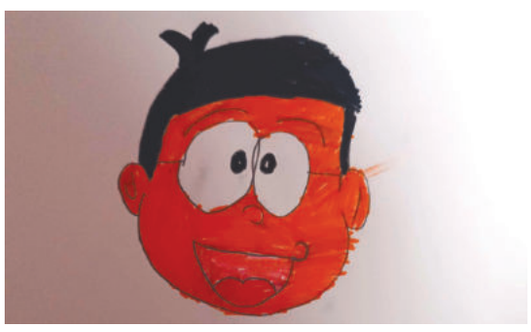
There was snow when I woke up. It was all over our car. There was a very little. I went to the Paper Mill Park two times that day because there was snow.

Yesterday, there was snow and snow and snow. There was so much snow. That we could play all day. I didn't want to stop playing in the snow ever. Then today, there was even more snow. There was snow all over the house and the car.

You need to be careful before you go and play in the snow. If you do, If you do not wear warm clothes, you can get sick. Fifty people have died because of the snow in the United States. This is because it was cold and the roads were slippery. Trees fall and hit homes and people. Be careful!

The schools were closed, so I got to spend time with my sister, Vidheha. We had a snowball fight. We hit each other with snowballs. We were able to attack dad and mom with snowballs. Hajurmuwa did not come out. though, as she had a cold. I wish I could have played with her. I really want to play in the snow again tomorrow.

(Zoya studies at Spiny Babbler Evolution, Lalitpur.)



Monsoon Kandel, Grade 3, LRI



Roshina Khadka, Grade VI, Fubright School, Bhaktapur



Aagaman Parajuli, Grade II, New Star Pole School

TRN PUZZLE NUMBER-407

All you have to do is to fill up in the seven boxes below with the numbers in such a way that the sum will be 581 whether you go diagonally, horizontally or vertically. The numbers should be 59 to 107 between. The number should not be used twice.

88	97	106	59	68	77	86
63	72	74	83	92	94	103
80	89	98	107	60	69	78

74	83	92	45	54	63	72
82	91	51	53	62	71	73
90	50	52	61	70	79	81
49	58	60	69	78	80	89
57	59	68	77	86	88	48
65	67	76	85	87	47	56
66	75	84	93	46	55	64

TRN PUZZLE SOLUTION-406

Prepared by: Bishwo Nath Kharel



Sailaja Dani, Grade III, Times International School